

Minecraft Successful

A Story-Driven Mission Book

Five players. Ten missions. One blocky world.

The Block Crew Chronicles

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The Block Crew

Stone — Veteran miner. Practical, experienced, stubborn.

Red — Crew leader. Ambitious, fast-talking, always scheming.

Brick — Enforcer. Hot-headed, loyal, always ready to fight.

Pick — Strategist. Cautious, smart, always has a plan.

Gear — Tech expert. Builder, inventor, redstone genius.

Chapter 1: The First Dig

The sun hadn't even broken the horizon when Stone found himself standing at the edge of the spawn point, a worn stone pickaxe in one hand and nothing in the other but the cold morning air.

"Coordinates."

The word came out flat, tired. He'd done this a hundred times. A thousand. But a man's gotta eat, and iron doesn't mine itself.

His communicator buzzed. The screen flickered to life with a single line of text:

Red: *You up?*

Stone grunted, tapping out a reply with his thumb.

Stone: *Born that way. What's the play?*

The response came fast. Red was always fast. That was his thing — quick fingers, quicker mouth, and eyes that saw every angle before anyone else knew there was a game to play.

Red: *Got a buyer. Needs 16 iron ingots by sundown. Pays 4 emeralds. Clean deal, no questions.*

Stone: *16 ore or 16 ingots?*

Red: *Ingots. Buyer doesn't smelt.*

Stone: *That's a full day's work for 4 emeralds. You know that.*

Red: *I know the rent's due tomorrow and your last score was a bust. Don't make me beg, old man.*

Stone stared at the screen. The words "old man" lingered longer than they should have. He pocketed the communicator and looked up at the first pale streaks of light creeping over the treeline.

Sundown. That gave him about ten minutes of daylight to get underground, maybe nine hours of real digging. Plenty of time if the world cooperated. If it didn't... well, he'd slept in worse places than a dirt hole.

He tapped out one last message: *Y-11. Don't message me until I message you.*

Red's reply came as a single emoji: a pickaxe.

Stone smiled despite himself. Kid had style. He had to give him that.

The first shaft went straight down. Three blocks of dirt, then stone. Stone — the man, not the material — dropped a ladder from his inventory and began his descent. Torch in one hand, pickaxe in the other. The rhythm was automatic: place ladder, descend one block, place torch, descend two more, repeat.

The light from the surface shrank to a pinprick above him. Then nothing but torch glow and the sound of his own breathing.

Twenty blocks down, he hit a cave. He could hear it before he saw it — the drip of water, the distant rattle of bones. A skeleton. Somewhere in the dark.

Stone pulled his sword, an iron blade chipped from half a dozen fights he'd been too slow to avoid. He listened. The rattle was coming from his left, maybe thirty blocks out. Not close enough to be a problem. Not yet.

He marked the cave entrance with a torch and kept digging. A branching tunnel to the right caught his eye — exposed coal, some iron peeking out from the wall. Tempting. But Red didn't pay him for stray ore. Sixteen ingots meant sixteen blocks of raw iron, minimum. He needed a vein, not scraps.

Deeper.

Y-14. Three hours in. His inventory was a mess of cobblestone, coal, and the three iron ore he'd managed to scavenge from exposed cave walls. At this rate, he'd be lucky to make eight by sundown. The buyer would laugh. Red would lose his cut. Stone would be back at the spawn point tomorrow with nothing but the shirt on his back and another debt to his name.

"Not today," he muttered.

He picked a spot and started a branch mine. Tunnel for thirty blocks, leave three blocks of stone between each tunnel, repeat. It was boring work. Mind-numbing. But it was honest, and it worked.

Block after block after block. The pickaxe swung in steady arcs. Cobblestone piled up in his inventory. The torches behind him marked a trail of orange stars through the black.

And then — *clink*.

The sound was unmistakable. Metal on metal. Stone froze, pulling the pickaxe back for a gentler swing. The block cracked and crumbled, and there it was: iron ore. Four blocks clustered together, their beige speckled faces gleaming in the torchlight.

"There we go."

He mined them quickly, efficiently, dropping each block into his inventory with the satisfaction of a gambler hitting a streak. Four down. Thirteen to go.

Y-11. The sweet spot. Deep enough for iron to spawn in abundance, not so deep that lava pools became a constant threat. Stone had spent more time at this elevation than anywhere else in the world. It felt like home, in a strange way. A dark, cramped, claustrophobic home, but home nonetheless.

The branch mine expanded. Six iron. Nine. Twelve.

He was on a roll now. The rhythm was back, that flow state where the world narrowed to pickaxe and stone, where time blurred and the only thing that existed was the next block and the one after that.

Then he heard it.

A low, bubbling hiss.

Stone's pickaxe stopped mid-swing. He leaned forward, peering into the darkness beyond his torchlight. There — just visible at the edge of his vision — a flicker of orange light. Not torchlight. Something angrier.

Lava.

He crept forward, sword drawn, until the full extent of the problem came into view. A lava pool. Twenty blocks across at least, stretching across the next three tunnels he'd planned to dig. The air shimmered with heat, and the bubbling sound echoed off the stone walls.

Stone exhaled slowly. "That's gonna be a problem."

He could go around it. Add another ten, maybe fifteen minutes to the route. But time was already tight, and the sun was climbing toward midday. Or he could get creative.

He scanned the pool. The lava was high — level with his feet. That meant it was a surface pool, not a fall. If he was careful, he could tunnel beneath it.

If.

Stone wet his lips and started digging. Three blocks down. A horizontal tunnel under the pool. He could feel the heat seeping through the stone above him, could hear the lava hissing and popping through the cracks. One wrong move — one block broken in the wrong place — and the entire ceiling would open, drowning him in molten rock.

"Just another Tuesday," he muttered.

The tunnel stretched on. Ten blocks. Twenty. The heat was oppressive now, sweat beading on his forehead and dripping into his eyes. He didn't stop to wipe it away. He couldn't afford to stop.

One block at a time. Stay low. Stay lucky.

And then the tunnel emerged on the other side, and the heat faded, and Stone let out a breath he didn't realize he'd been holding.

Behind him, the lava pool bubbled on, indifferent to his survival.

He found the motherlode at Y-11, just past the lava pool's reach. Sixteen blocks of iron ore in a single sprawling vein, snaking through the stone like a fossilized serpent. Stone laughed — a hoarse, genuine laugh that echoed through the tunnels and bounced back at him.

"That's it. That's the one."

He mined with renewed energy, each block falling faster than the last. Twelve. Fourteen. Sixteen. He held the final block of raw iron in his hand, turning it over in the torchlight. It was just ore. Common rock with a metallic glint. But to Stone, it was a lifeline.

He checked his inventory. Sixteen iron ore. More than enough to yield the ingots Red needed. The smelting would take time, but he could do it in his surface camp, cook the ore while the sun dropped toward the horizon.

Stone: *Got it. Sixteen ore, heading up.*

The reply came instantly.

Red: *Told you. EZ.*

Stone: *Nearly became a block of obsidian down here. EZ my ass.*

Red: *You're too stubborn to die. Meet at the usual spot. I'll bring the buyer.*

Stone pocketed the communicator and began the long climb up the ladder shaft. The torches flickered as he passed, casting his shadow long and thin against the stone walls. Behind him, the deep dark settled back into silence, waiting for the next fool with a pickaxe.

The surface was chaos.

Not the dangerous kind — the *beautiful* kind. The sun hung low in the sky, painting the landscape in shades of gold and amber. A breeze rustled through the oak trees near his camp. Birds chirped. A rabbit hopped past, utterly unconcerned with the grime-covered man emerging from a hole in the ground.

Stone had never been so happy to see sunlight.

He built a quick smelting array: three furnaces fed by a coal vein he'd stripped on the way up. Each furnace got its share of iron ore and fuel, and soon the *tick-tick-tick* of cooking metal filled the air. He sat on a block of dirt, watching the flames, letting the warmth wash over him.

Sixteen ingots. By the time the sun touched the horizon, he had them stacked neatly in his inventory, still warm from the furnaces.

Red showed up right on time, emerging from the treeline with a swagger that belonged to someone twice his size. He was young — barely out of his teens — with a shock of red hair that gave him his name and eyes that never stopped moving.

"Called it," Red said, tossing a pouch at Stone's feet. Four emeralds clinked against each other inside. "Told the buyer you were the best. He wants to talk to you."

Stone picked up the pouch, weighing it in his palm. "Talk about what?"

"Dunno. Said he's got a job. A *big* one. Said if this went smooth, he'd be in touch." Red's grin widened. "Told you these easy scores lead somewhere."

Stone grunted. "This wasn't easy."

"Nothing ever is with you." Red turned, already heading back into the trees. "Get some sleep, old man. I got a feeling tomorrow's gonna be a long one."

He disappeared into the shadows, leaving Stone alone with the cooling furnaces and four bright emeralds.

Stone looked down at the ingots in his hand. Sixteen. Four emeralds. A buyer with a "big job."

Something told him this was just the beginning.

End of Chapter 1

Chapter 2: Bone Rush

The safehouse was a hole in the wall—literally. Someone had dug out a chunk of hillside in the middle of nowhere, threw down a couple of furnaces, a crafting table, and called it operational. A single torch flickered on the cobblestone floor, casting long shadows that danced across the walls like restless spirits.

Stone leaned against the wall, arms crossed, watching the flame gut and sputter. His gear was still damp from the river he'd crossed to get here. The leather tunic clung to his skin, and his iron sword—freshly sharpened—hung at his hip.

Across the room, Red paced. His boots scraped against the stone floor in a steady rhythm. Grindstone squeak. Pivot. Scrape. Pivot. He'd been at it for ten minutes.

"You gonna wear a hole through the floor or are you gonna tell me what we're doing?" Stone asked.

Red stopped. He looked up, and there was that glint in his eye again. The one that meant trouble.

"We're going hunting."

"Define hunting."

Red reached into his inventory and tossed something at Stone's feet. A bone clattered across the floor, coming to rest against his boot. Picked clean. Bleached white by the desert sun.

"Bones," Red said. "We need thirty-two of them. Fresh."

Stone picked up the bone, turning it over in his hand. "You want me to kill skeletons."

"I want you to bring me their ribs, yeah."

A heavy bootstep echoed from the entrance. Stone turned to see a figure filling the doorway—broad-shouldered, shaven-headed, with a scar that ran from his left eyebrow to his jawline like someone had tried to carve his face open and nearly succeeded. He wore iron chestplate, no shirt beneath it, and carried a stone axe over his shoulder like it weighed nothing.

"This the new guy?" The man's voice was gravel and broken glass.

Red gestured lazily. "Stone, this is Brick. Brick, Stone."

Brick stepped into the torchlight, looking Stone up and down like he was inspecting a cut of meat. "He don't look like much."

"He's got hands," Red said. "Seen him move. He'll do."

"He better." Brick cracked his neck, a series of pops that sounded like twigs snapping. "I ain't carrying dead weight."

Stone met his gaze. Held it. "Nobody asked you to carry me."

Brick's lip curled into something between a grin and a snarl. "Cute. We'll see how cute you are when a skeleton arrow punches through that pretty leather of yours."

"Enough," Red said, and the word landed like a blade. Both of them went quiet. "Listen up. Here's the play."

He pulled a worn map from his inventory, spread it across the crafting table. The edges were frayed, the ink smudged in places, but the landmarks were clear enough. He tapped a spot in the southeastern corner.

"Desert biome, about two clicks east of here. There's a temple somewhere in this stretch. Old sandstone. Buried chambers. Probably crawling with the dead."

"Probably?" Stone said.

"Definitely. I've had scouts circle it. Daytime, you can see the skeletons shambling around the entrance. Nighttime..." He let the pause hang. "Nighttime, the husks come out."

"Husks," Brick muttered. "Hate those bastards. They don't burn."

"Exactly." Red straightened up. "So here's the deal. You two go in at dusk. Clear the area. Get me thirty-two bones. The temple's a bonus—if there's anything worth looting in those lower chambers, it's yours. I just want the bones."

"And if we don't come back?" Stone asked.

Red smiled. It wasn't a warm smile. "Then I find someone else."

Brick grunted, already heading for the entrance. "Let's move, pretty boy. Sun's dropping."

The desert was a different world once the sun started to sink.

Stone had seen deserts before—spent a night or two crossing them, keeping his head down, dodging the things that stirred after dark. But he'd never watched one *change*. The orange sand turned amber, then copper, then a deep bruised purple as the last slivers of daylight bled out along the horizon.

The air cooled fast. What had been dry heat against his skin became a chill that crept down his collar. The wind picked up, carrying sand that stung his eyes and gritted between his teeth.

Brick walked ahead of him, silent now, the stone axe resting on his shoulder. His footsteps left deep impressions in the sand that the wind was already erasing.

They crested a dune, and there it was.

The temple rose out of the desert floor like a monument to something forgotten. Sandstone blocks, weathered and pitted, stacked in that unmistakable shape—tall pillars flanking the entrance, a grand staircase leading up to a dark doorway. Time and wind had done their damage; cracks ran through the pillars like veins, and sand had piled up against the base, nearly burying the bottom step.

But it wasn't the architecture that made Stone stop.

It was the sound.

Bones grinding against bones. The shuffle of dry feet dragging through sand. And underneath it all, a low, hollow moan that seemed to come from everywhere and nowhere at once.

"You hear that?" Stone whispered.

"I'm not deaf," Brick said. He'd stopped too, his grip tightening on the axe handle. "They're already out."

The first skeleton emerged from behind a pillar.

It moved with that jerky, wrong-footed gait that all skeletons had, as if its joints didn't quite know how to work together. Its bow was already drawn, the string pulled taut, an arrow nocked and gleaming faintly in the dying light.

It saw them.

The rattle that came out of its skull was unmistakable. A warning. A call to arms.

"Here we go," Brick said, and charged.

Stone swore under his breath and followed.

The fight was chaos.

Brick hit the first skeleton before it could loose its arrow, the stone axe coming down in a brutal arc that shattered the thing's ribcage and sent bones scattering across the sand. But the sound brought more of them—two more skeletons from behind the pillars, a third from the top of the staircase, arrows already slicing through the air.

One caught Stone in the shoulder.

Not deep. The leather absorbed most of it, but the impact staggered him, and the sharp sting of broken skin sent a jolt through his arm. He yanked the arrow out, blood dark against the fletching, and dove behind a pillar as a second arrow thudded into the sandstone where his head had been.

"Keep moving!" Brick roared. He was already closing on the stairway skeleton, taking an arrow to the chestplate that sparked but didn't slow him down. "Don't let them pin you!"

Stone rolled out from behind the pillar, sword in hand. A skeleton was advancing on his left, bow raised, but it was too close now—he closed the distance in three strides and put his blade through its sternum. The thing crumpled, bones clattering, and for a moment there was silence.

Then the husks came.

They rose from the sand like the dead they were—bodies bloated, skin cracked and leathery, eyes glowing with that sickly yellow light. There were three of them at first. Then five. Then Stone lost count.

"Back!" Brick shouted. "Back to the dune!"

But there was no going back. They were surrounded.

Stone set his jaw, raised his sword, and fought.

It felt like hours. It might have been.

Stone lost track of how many he put down. Arrows sprouted from his leg, his side, his off-hand arm. Each one he pulled out and kept going. Brick was a machine beside him, axe rising and falling, each swing taking down another husk, another skeleton, his chestplate dented and scored but his grip never loosening.

And then, suddenly, there were no more.

The last husk crumbled to the sand, its body dissolving into particles of dust that scattered on the breeze. The desert was

quiet again. The only sounds were the wind and the ragged gasps of two men catching their breath.

Stone dropped to his knees. His hands were shaking. His sword was slick with—something. Bone dust. Rot. He didn't want to think about it.

Brick stood over him, chest heaving, staring down at the carnage. Skeletons and husks lay in pieces all around them. Bones littered the sand like pale driftwood.

"Not bad," Brick said.

Stone looked up. "Did you just compliment me?"

"Don't let it go to your head." Brick reached down and grabbed his arm, hauling him to his feet. "Come on. Bones don't collect themselves."

They gathered them in silence. Thirty-two. Some cracked, some whole. Stone counted twice, then a third time, stuffing them into his inventory until the tally came up right.

"Temple," Brick said, jerking his head toward the entrance. "Red said it's ours if we want it."

Stone was exhausted. Every muscle screamed. But he nodded.

The temple's interior was dark, the air thick and stale. Torches—ancient, unlit—lined the walls. The floor was a checkerboard of sandstone and what looked like... pressure plates.

"Careful," Stone said, stepping over the first one. "Tripwire could be anything."

Brick snorted but followed his lead.

They moved through the upper chamber carefully, checking every block, every corner. The lower levels were accessed through a hole in the floor—a drop of about ten blocks into darkness below.

Stone went first, landing in a crouch, sword ready.

More chambers. More darkness. And in the corner of the third room, half-buried in sand...

A chest.

Brick's eyes lit up. "Jackpot."

He took a step toward it. Then another.

"Brick. Stop."

The words came out before Stone could think. Something was wrong. The chest was too exposed. Too perfect. And the block in front of it...

"Look," Stone said, pointing.

Brick froze. His eyes followed Stone's finger to the floor directly in front of the chest. A pressure plate. Sandstone-colored. Almost invisible in the dim light.

"That's a trap," Stone said quietly. "You step on that, the whole ceiling comes down. Or the floor opens up. Or both."

Brick stared at the chest. The pressure plate. Back at the chest. His jaw tightened.

"How'd you spot it?"

"Does it matter?"

For a long moment, Brick didn't answer. Then he let out a breath, his shoulders dropping. "No," he said. "No, it don't."

They skirted the pressure plate, hugging the wall, and found a hidden tunnel leading deeper. No more traps. But no more treasure, either. Just a forgotten shrine, long since picked clean.

They emerged from the temple as the first gray light of dawn touched the horizon. The desert was quiet. Peaceful, almost.

Stone's inventory held thirty-two bones. His body held four arrows, two cracked ribs, and a hundred new bruises.

"Red's gonna want to see you," Brick said, not looking at him. "You did good in there, Stone. For a pretty boy."

Stone almost laughed. "I'll take that."

Red was waiting at the safehouse, the same grin on his face as when they'd left. He counted the bones one by one, laying them out on the crafting table like a merchant tallying his goods.

"Thirty-two," he said, nodding. "Good work. Both of you."

Brick grunted and slumped into a corner, already pulling out a bandage for a gash on his arm.

Red turned to Stone. "You're wondering what they're for."

"The thought crossed my mind."

Red picked up one of the bones, twirling it between his fingers. "There's a guy. Works out of a village about a day north of here. He's building something. Needs materials. And I mean *specific* materials." He set the bone down. "Bones are just the beginning."

Stone waited.

Red leaned in, his voice dropping. "There's a stronghold, Stone. Deep underground. Full of things that'll kill you before you see them. But if we can get what's down there..."

He let the words hang, watching Stone's face.

"Interested?"

Stone thought about the desert. The skeletons. The husks. The pressure plate that would have killed them both.

He thought about the chest he'd never opened, and whatever was still down there waiting.

"Yeah," he said. "I'm interested."

Red's grin widened.

"Good. Because we're just getting started."

End of Chapter 2

Chapter 3: Gold Heist

"First rule of the Nether: don't look up."

The obsidian frame stood twelve blocks tall against the gray stone of the basement — a gateway to hell itself, dormant and waiting. Stone had built it brick by brick over three days, mining obsidian from a submerged cave system and hauling it back through the night. Now it loomed over them like a monument to bad decisions.

"Light it," said a voice from the shadows.

Stone turned. The new guy — Pick — leaned against the wall with the calm of someone who'd already seen everything twice. He was shorter than Stone, with sharp eyes that missed nothing and hands that moved like they'd been born holding tools. A professional. Red had vouched for him.

"You sure about this?" Brick rumbled from across the room. The big man folded his arms. "I heard things live in there. Things that don't like company."

"That's the point," Pick said. "Those things drop gold."

Stone struck the flint and steel. The spark caught the obsidian's edge and the portal roared to life — a swirling vortex of purple and black, ten feet tall, pulsing like a heartbeat. The air turned thick and hot. A sound like distant screams bled through from the other side.

"Alright," Stone said, gripping his diamond sword. "Crew up. We're going in."

The first thing that hit them was the heat. Not like a desert. Like standing inside a furnace with your skin peeled off. The second thing was the color — everything burned in shades of red, orange, and brown. Massive mushroom-like fungi towered overhead, their stalks thicker than trees. Rivers of lava cascaded down cliffs, lighting the cavern with an angry orange glow.

"Where the hell are we?" Brick muttered.

"The Nether," Pick said, already scanning the horizon. "And we're not alone."

Something shrieked in the distance — high-pitched, echoing off the cavern walls. A moment later, a floating cube of flesh drifted past a lava fall, its single eye swiveling in their direction. It made a sound like a wounded animal and disappeared behind a pillar of netherrack.

"Ghast," Pick said. "Bad news. Stay low, don't make eye contact, and for the love of everything — don't look up for too long."

Stone grunted. "How do you know all this?"

"I read."

They moved through the Nether like ghosts, sticking close to the walls. The terrain was brutal — jagged cliffs, sudden drops into lava, narrow bridges of netherrack that crumbled beneath their boots. The heat shimmer made everything waver, and the constant hum of lava filled their ears like the Nether was alive and breathing.

A group of strange creatures shuffled ahead. They were pale, with long arms and snouts, wearing gold ornaments that glittered in the hellish light. Each one carried a golden sword or crossbow, and their grunts sounded almost like language.

"Piglins," Pick whispered. "This is our payday."

"Good," Stone said, gripping his sword. "Let's take 'em."

"Hold up." Pick's voice cut like a blade. "You charge in swinging, they swarm you. There's dozens in these halls. You kill one, the rest come running. And they hit hard."

"So what's your play?"

Pick reached into his pack and pulled out three pieces of gold armor — a chestplate, leggings, and boots. They were crude, hammered together from nuggets and ingots, but they gleamed in the lava light.

"Gold," he said. "Piglins love gold. You wear it, they treat you like one of their own. Mostly."

"You want us to dress up like them?" Brick scoffed.

"I want us to walk out of here with twenty-four gold ingots without fighting an army. Yes."

Stone stared at the armor. Then at the piglins. Then back at Pick. "How do you know they won't attack anyway?"

Pick shrugged. "I don't. But I know what happens if we fight — one of us dies, probably in lava, and the gold burns with him. I'll take my odds."

It was the kind of logic Stone respected. Calculated. Cold. He grabbed a gold chestplate and pulled it over his head. It was heavy and uncomfortable, but the piglins nearby stopped their shuffling and stared — heads tilted, curious, but not hostile.

"Huh," Brick said, donning his own gold leggings. "That's unsettling."

"You get used to it," Pick said. He was already wearing his gold set, moving toward the piglins with slow, deliberate steps. His hands were empty, palms open.

The bartering was awkward and terrifying.

Pick approached the nearest piglin — a hulking creature with a golden sword and tusks that could gut a cow. He held out a gold ingot. The piglin sniffed it, grunted, and shoved a handful of gilded blackstone at him.

"Not what we need," Pick muttered. He tried again with another piglin, getting a few obsidian blocks. On the third attempt, a smaller piglin with a crossbow took his gold and dropped a cluster of gold nuggets in return.

"Keep going," Stone said. "We need twenty-four total."

They bartered for what felt like hours. The piglins drove a hard bargain — sometimes giving pearls or quartz, sometimes just grunting and walking away. But gradually, the nuggets stacked up. Six. Twelve. Eighteen.

Brick was on his knees, holding out a gold block to a piglin that seemed to be the group's leader. The piglin took it, examined it, and grunted. Then it reached into a pouch and poured a stream of gold nuggets into Brick's waiting hands.

"That's the score," Brick whispered. "That put us at twenty-four."

"Back out slow," Pick said. "No sudden movements. No running."

They started retreating, step by painful step, keeping their eyes on the piglins. The creatures watched them go with what might have been acknowledgment — or might have been hunger. Either way, they didn't follow.

"Made it," Stone breathed, once they were behind a netherrack ridge. "That was—"

The scream cut him off.

It came from above — a piercing, high-pitched wail that seemed to drill into their skulls. Stone looked up and saw it: a ghast, massive and pale, drifting out from behind a basalt pillar. Its tentacles hung beneath it like roots, and its eye was fixed on them with an intelligence that felt personal.

"Run!" Pick shouted.

The fireball hit the ground where they'd been standing, exploding with a force that sent Stone flying. He hit the netherrack hard, his ears ringing, gold armor scorched. Through blurred vision, he saw the ghastr winding up for another shot.

"It's gonna shred us!" Brick yelled, scrambling for cover.

"No it's not." Brick's voice was low, steady. He'd stopped running. He was standing in the open, facing the ghastr, a fire charge in each hand.

"Brick, what the hell are you doing?!"

"I saw a guy do this once." Brick lit the charges and waited. The ghastr screamed and fired — a massive fireball streaking toward them. Brick timed it perfectly. He threw both charges at the incoming projectile.

The explosion was blinding.

When the smoke cleared, the ghastr was gone. A single piece of gunpowder drifted down through the air, landing at Brick's feet. He picked it up without a word.

"Show-off," Stone said, coughing.

"Told you I read," Brick said, and for the first time all day, he smiled.

They found the portal back to the Overworld just as the heat was becoming unbearable. The obsidian frame was half-built, abandoned by some previous traveler, and they finished it with the last of their materials. Stone lit it, and they stepped through into the cool night air of a birch forest.

The temperature change was like being born again. They collapsed onto the grass, staring up at the stars, breathing air that didn't burn.

"That," Pick said, "is the worst place I have ever been."

"I liked it," Brick said.

"You would."

They made it back to base by midnight. Red was waiting on the front porch of their operations shack, lantern in hand. He looked them over — scorched, battered, but alive — and raised an eyebrow.

"How much?"

Stone upended his pack. Twenty-four gold ingots spilled across the wooden planks, gleaming in the lantern light.

Red's eyes went wide. "That's GTA money right there. More than we've made in the last three jobs combined."

"It cost us," Stone said. "We need better gear. Armor that can take a hit. Weapons that actually hurt."

Red nodded. "I know a guy. Tools like you wouldn't believe. But he'll want payment." He looked at the gold. "Looks like we've got it."

As Red gathered the ingots, Pick pulled Stone aside. His voice was low, serious.

"That portal in the basement? Keep it open. We're going back."

"Like hell we are."

"Listen." Pick's eyes were hard. "That place is a goldmine. Piglins trade for anything. Ender pearls, blaze rods, quartz — ma-

terials you can't find anywhere in the Overworld. We get organized, we gear up properly, we could build a crew that runs this server."

Stone studied him in the dark. The new guy was ambitious. Calculated. Dangerous.

"I'll think about it."

"Don't think too long," Pick said. "Someone else will figure it out. And they won't be as smart about it as us."

Stone didn't answer. But he didn't say no either.

Loot Summary

- **24 Gold Ingots** traded for full enchanted gear
- **1 Gunpowder** (ghost kill)
- **Nether Quartz** (bartered from piglins)
- **Obsidian** (portal materials)

Crew Status

- **Stone** — Level up! Endurance +1, Nether Survival +1
 - **Brick** — Level up! Combat Reflexes +1, Ghost Slayer unlocked
 - **Pick** — New crew member. Skills: Piglin Diplomacy, Tactical Planning
 - **Red** — Gear Upgraded (new supplier contact unlocked)
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Next Mission: *The Black Market* — Stone's crew hits a hidden underground trading hall to flip their Nether goods for legendary equipment. But the hall has rules. And the hall has guards.

Chapter 4: Emerald Exchange

P layers: Stone · Pick · Gear

Mission: Find a village, set up a trading hall, and trade for 32 emeralds

Reward: 3 Emeralds each + Hero of the Village

The sun was a line of gold bleeding across the eastern horizon as Stone, Pick, and their new companion crested the ridge.

Below them, a cluster of sandstone and oak buildings sat nestled in the crook of a river. Wheat fields stretched in neat rows. A bell tower rose from the center. Sheep grazed lazily by the banks.

"A village," Pick breathed, shielding his eyes. "An actual, honest-to-Herobrine village."

Stone nodded, already counting. "At least a dozen houses. Maybe two dozen villagers. That's a lot of trades."

"Trades we can't make without a proper setup," said the third figure.

Gear was shorter than both of them, with goggles pushed up on his forehead and a redstone torch dangling from his belt. His chestplate was etched with circuits—glowing lines of copper and

lapis that pulsed with a faint hum. Everything about him moved with the efficiency of a well-oiled piston.

"I've been designing this for weeks," he said, pulling a scroll from his pack. The paper unrolled to reveal detailed schematics—lecterns, grindstones, brewing stands, and a dozen other workstation layouts. "Give me an hour and these villagers will be trading their grandmas for a single stick."

"You're terrifying," Pick said.

"I prefer *efficient*."

The Plains Village of Oakrest

They descended into the village as the roosters began to crow. A farmer villager near the river looked up, tilted its head, and grunted. A butcher leaned out of a stone house, meat cleaver in hand, before deciding the newcomers weren't worth the effort.

Stone walked the perimeter, sword out, scanning the flat plains. The village was vulnerable—no walls, no fortifications, just open fields in every direction. A few wolves roamed near the outskirts, but they'd be useless against anything serious.

"We're exposed here," he said when he returned.

"We won't be long," Gear replied, already dropping his pack in the center of the village. "Two hours. Maybe three. Then we're gone."

Pick had his eye on the villagers. "The farmer has potatoes. The librarian has four bookshelves. I saw a weaponsmith—"

"Focus on emeralds," Stone said. "That's the mission."

"Always the mission with you."

Stone's jaw tightened. "That's how we survive."

Gear ignored them both. He was already placing blocks—a lectern here, a grindstone there, a smithing table near the blacksmith's house. He worked with the careful precision of someone who had done this a hundred times in his head.

"Pick, I need you to break those hay bales and trade with the farmer first. Emeralds for wheat. We'll convert through the librarian for enchanted books, then sell those to the weaponsmith. Three-layer conversion. Clean."

"Clean," Pick repeated, grinning. "I like it."

"You'd like anything that doesn't involve swinging a pickaxe for once," Stone muttered.

"Not wrong."

Gear snapped his fingers. "Move. The market doesn't build itself."

The Trading Begins

The morning turned into a rhythm.

Pick worked the farmer—wheat for emeralds, emeralds for more wheat, cycling through the trades until the farmer's stock depleted and restocked. Gear stood by with a notepad, tracking every transaction, optimizing the flow like a server managing traffic.

"We're at eight emeralds," Gear announced after the first twenty minutes. "Pick, switch to the librarian. Stone—I need more paper. The cartographer has a trade locked behind exploration maps. If we can unlock it—"

"On it."

Stone scoured the village, collecting sugarcane from the riverbank, crafting paper, feeding the cartographer's demand. The trades stacked. Eight emeralds became twelve. Twelve became eighteen.

The villagers grunted and squeaked their approval. One of the farmer's children threw a poppy at Pick's feet.

"See?" Pick said, pocketing two more emeralds. "They like me."

"They like your emeralds," Stone said.

"Same thing."

Gear had established three workstations by now, each one carefully positioned to maximize workflow. The lectern faced the center square. The grindstone was under a roof overhang for shade. The smithing table sat next to a lava pit he'd dug himself, the glow casting long shadows across the cobblestone.

"Twenty-four," Gear called out. "Eight to go."

Pick wiped sweat from his brow. "I could do this all day."

"Don't," Stone said, eyeing the horizon. "Something's off."

The winds had shifted.

The sheep had stopped grazing.

The Pillagers

The first crossbow bolt buried itself in the dirt three feet from Gear's head.

"INCOMING!"

The war horn split the air—a deep, guttural blast that sent chickens scattering and villagers screaming. From the northern treeline, a column of gray figures emerged. Ragged banners. Pale, stitched skin. Crossbows glinting in the midday sun.

Pillagers.

A full patrol. No—not a patrol. A *raid*.

"Nine of them!" Pick shouted, counting. "Ten—no, twelve!"

"We need to evacuate the villagers—" Stone started.

"No time." Gear had already dropped his notepad and was pulling a bow from his pack. "If they trigger the raid horn, more will come. We end this here. Fast."

Stone grabbed his shield from his back, the wood creaking as he locked it onto his arm. "Pick—the church roof. High ground."

"You read my mind."

They ran.

The Defense of Oakrest

Pick took the bell tower in three leaps, boots finding footing on windowsills and crossbeams until he was perched on the wooden balcony, bow drawn. Below, the pillagers spread into a

loose formation—disciplined, practiced. These weren't random wanderers. They knew what they were doing.

"Pick! Left flank!"

Pick pivoted. A pillager with an iron-tipped arrow was taking aim at a farmer frozen in the middle of the road. Pick let his arrow fly—a clean, whistling shot that caught the raider in the shoulder. The pillager stumbled, the shot going wide, shattering a window.

"Get inside!" Pick roared at the farmer.

The villager scrambled.

Stone was on the ground, shield raised, advancing. Crossbow bolts thudded against his shield like heavy rain. One. Two. Three. His arm numbed with each impact, but he didn't stop. He couldn't.

"Gear—the avenues! Block the gaps!"

Gear was already moving. He pulled blocks of cobblestone from his inventory and slammed them into the gaps between houses, sealing off the alleyways. The pillagers were funneled now—forced into the main square where Stone stood waiting.

"Ten seconds," Gear yelled. "Give me ten seconds."

Stone drew his sword.

The first pillager rounded the corner. Stone stepped inside its range before it could fire, his blade finding the gap under its arm. The creature crumpled. Two more followed. Stone banged his sword against his shield—a challenge.

"COME ON!"

They came.

Pick's arrows rained from above, taking down the raiders who tried to circle around. A vindicator charged with an axe raised high—Pick dropped him with an arrow through the knee. The vindicator howled, collapsed, and Gear finished him with a well-placed stone sword.

"Twenty-two!" Gear shouted. Wait—he'd been counting emeralds. Now he counted bodies.

A ravager—massive, horned, snorting smoke—stamped into the square. Its rider raised a banner and the remaining pillagers rallied.

"Stone! Take the rider!"

Stone didn't hesitate. He charged, shield low, sword angled. The ravager stomped—he rolled, came up under its neck, and slashed across the rider's leg. The banner bearer tumbled, and Pick's arrow found its mark before the raider hit the ground.

The ravager turned, confused without its handler.

Stone sheathed his sword, drew his bow, and put three arrows into its skull.

The beast fell.

Silence.

Aftermath

The raid horn lay shattered in the dirt.

Pick slid down the church roof, landing with a puff of dust. Gear leaned against a workbench, chest heaving. Stone stood in

the center of the square, surrounded by pillager bodies, shield cracked, sword dripping.

One by one, the villagers emerged.

The farmer. The butcher. The weaponsmith. The librarian. A child clutching a stuffed sheep.

They stared at the bodies. Then at Stone.

And then the farmer bowed.

It spread like a wave. The butcher bowed. The librarian. The cartographer. Every villager in Oakrest bent at the waist, offering a gesture of respect that Stone had never seen from a villager before.

"What is this?" he asked quietly.

Particles of light began to swirl around them—golden, warm, like fireflies at dusk. The air hummed with an energy that made Stone's skin prickle.

"Hero of the Village," Gear whispered. "I read about it. Never thought I'd see it."

A villager approached—the old librarian, his spectacles askew, his robes torn from the chaos. In his trembling hands, he held out an emerald block. Not a single gem. A full block.

"Oh," Pick breathed. "Oh, that's beautiful."

Then came the rest. Enchanted books. An iron sword. Bread—dozens of loaves. The villagers pressed gifts into their hands, chattering in their guttural language, pointing at the sky where the particles swirled, offering everything they had.

Gear counted the emeralds they'd already collected. "Twenty-eight," he said.

Stone knelt, accepting an emerald from a small child. He looked at Gear.

"Twenty-nine."

Pick laughed, pulling a handful of gems from the donations. "Thirty-two. Done."

"We're done," Stone said. He looked at the villagers, the bread in his hands, the smiling child. "Mission complete."

The Departure

They left Oakrest as the sun began to set, the village behind them bathed in orange light. The villagers had already started rebuilding. Three new iron golems patrolled the perimeter. The farmer's son waved from the bell tower.

"That wasn't so bad," Pick said.

"Speak for yourself." Gear was nursing a bruise on his ribs. "My back hurts, my notepad is ruined, and I'm pretty sure I lost a redstone torch in the river."

"You can build another."

"I can. I will."

Stone walked ahead, silent, the emerald block heavy in his pack. Pick caught up with him.

"You okay?"

Stone didn't answer for a long moment. Then: "They didn't have walls. That village. They were sitting ducks."

"So?"

"So, next time—" He stopped. Shook his head. "Never mind."

Gear and Pick exchanged a glance.

"The grindstone's in my blood," Stone said finally. "But that doesn't mean I want to watch people lose everything."

Pick clapped him on the shoulder. "That's almost human of you, Stone."

"Shut up."

"Hero of the Village."

"I said *shut up*."

Gear laughed—a rare, rusty sound. The three of them walked into the setting sun, packs full of emeralds, the memory of a grateful village warm at their backs.

Behind them, the bell of Oakrest tolled once.

Not a warning.

A thank you.

Mission Stats

Objective

Status

Locate a village

Oakrest discovered (plains biome)

Set up trading infrastructure

3 workstations built

Objective**Status**

Trade for 32 emeralds

32 emeralds acquired

Survive

Pillager raid defeated

Protect the villagers

All villagers survived

Bounty**3 Emeralds each + Hero of the Village
status**

"You can build a market in an hour. You can't build trust."

— Unknown, later found carved into the bell tower of Oakrest

Chapter 5: Diamond Score

The crew gathered in Red's underground base, the glowstone lanterns casting long shadows across the cobblestone floor. A crafting table sat in the center, surrounded by chests overflowing with iron, coal, and the spoils of their last dozen expeditions.

Red stood at the head of the table, arms crossed. Behind him, a map of the underground stretched across the wall, marked with X's where they'd explored and question marks where they hadn't.

"Alright, listen up," Red said, his voice carrying the weight of a man who'd been thinking about this for days. "We've been scraping by with iron. Piglins laugh at us. The End is a joke without better gear. It's time for the big leagues."

Stone leaned against the wall, arms folded. "You're talking about diamonds."

"Three of them," Red said. "Minimum. We need an enchantment table. Without one, we're stuck in the stone age while the world moves on."

Pick stepped forward, unrolling a schematic onto the crafting table. The torchlight flickered over his detailed drawings—grid lines, measurements, and arrows pointing downward.

"Branch mining," Pick said, tapping the diagram with a calloused finger. "Y-level negative fifty-eight. That's the sweet spot for diamond generation since the 1.18 update. We dig down to that layer, then start a main tunnel. From there, we carve side tunnels—two blocks high, one block wide, every third block."

Gear scratched his head. "Every third block? Why not every other? Why not just strip the whole thing?"

"Efficiency." Pick's eyes lit up. "A 2x1 tunnel reveals four blocks per meter of tunnel—ceiling and floor included. By spacing tunnels three blocks apart, you maximize exposed faces per block mined. Every block you don't dig is a block you don't have to replace or light up. It's the highest diamond-per-minute ratio in the game."

Brick snorted. "Sounds like math class. Just dig down and find 'em."

"Yeah, and then a creeper drops on your head and you lose everything," Stone said dryly. "Pick's method works. I've seen it."

Red picked up a pickaxe—iron, well-worn from hours in the stone. "We go to Y=-58. We dig smart. We watch each other's backs. And we come back with diamonds."

The descent took twenty minutes. The crew moved in formation: Pick in front reading the coordinates from his F3 menu, Stone behind him with a shield raised, Gear and Brick bringing up the rear with torches and extra pickaxes.

The mine shaft spiraled downward, switchbacks carved into the stone to minimize fall damage. Every few blocks, Gear placed a torch on the right-hand wall—a trick Pick had taught them so they'd always know which way led out. Torches on the right meant heading in. Torches on the left meant heading home.

"Negative forty," Pick called out. "Forty-two. Forty-five. Almost there."

The temperature seemed to drop. The stone grew darker, veins of deepslate streaking through the walls like veins in marble. Lava pools bubbled in distant caves, casting an orange glow that danced across their faces.

"Fifty-eight," Pick said finally. "This is it."

They had landed in a small pocket—walls of deepslate surrounding them, the floor uneven and cracked. Pick immediately began marking the walls with charcoal, drawing lines where the branch tunnels would go.

"Main tunnel goes east," he said, already swinging his pick. "First branch tunnel starts here. We dig twelve blocks, then come back and start the next one three blocks over."

The rhythm was almost meditative. *Clink. Clink. Clink.* Pick's pickaxe bit into the deepslate, slower than stone but just as satisfying. Behind him, Stone collected the cobbled deepslate blocks, stacking them neatly for later use.

"Deepslate's tougher than regular stone," Pick said between swings. "Takes about twice as long to break. But that's where diamonds spawn now—deepslate layers. You want diamonds, you earn them."

Twenty blocks in, Gear's torch supply started running low. "We've got about sixty torches left," he said. "That's maybe four more tunnels."

Red nodded. "Conserve them. One torch every five blocks instead of three. And if someone finds diamonds, we consolidate."

Brick was on the third branch tunnel when everything went wrong.

He swung his pick into the deepslate, the block crumbling into cobble, and suddenly—*hiss*.

The green-and-black body materialized out of the darkness behind the broken block. A creeper. Staring at him with those empty black eyes. Its body began to puff, white cracks forming along its surface.

"CREEPER!" Brick shouted, scrambling backward. But in his panic, he forgot where the tunnel opening was. He'd dug fifteen blocks deep, the narrow 1x2 passage offering no room to maneuver.

HISS-POP-POP-POP-POP-

Stone moved before anyone could react. He shoved Brick aside, raising his shield at the last possible second. The explosion rocked the tunnel, sending chunks of deepslate flying. Stone skidded backward, his shield cracked down the middle but intact.

"Everyone okay?" Red shouted through the dust.

Stone coughed. "Shield's toast. But we're alive."

Brick was pale, breathing hard. "I... thanks, man."

"Don't mention it." Stone tossed the ruined shield aside. "Just watch where you're swinging."

Pick inspected the blast crater. "Good news—the creeper opened up more exposed blocks. Bad news—it collapsed part of the main tunnel. We'll need to reinforce."

Gear was already placing support pillars—cobblestone columns every three blocks to prevent cave-ins. "Should have done this from the start," he muttered. "Deepslate's dense but it doesn't hold well when you disturb the structural integrity."

"You sound like you've done this before," Red said.

"I read a book once." Gear shrugged. "Building with Stability. By this guy named Umber. Good stuff."

They pushed deeper. The hunger bar was dropping—fast. Down at Y=-58, you burn calories just standing still. The constant mining, the stress, the narrow escapes—it all added up.

Brick pulled out a loaf of bread from his inventory, only to find three bites left. "Anyone got extra food?"

"Half a steak," Stone said, tossing it over.

"Two cookies," Gear offered.

"I've got nothing," Pick said. "I assumed we'd be faster."

Red did a quick mental count. "We've got maybe two more tunnels worth of energy. After that, we go hungry. And hungry means slow mining. Slow mining means more time down here. More time means more mobs."

"More mobs means more creeping," Brick added sheepishly.

"We push forward," Red said. "Three more tunnels. If we don't find anything, we regroup and come back with better supplies."

The fifth tunnel was Pick's. He'd been methodical—swing, step, swing, step, torch, swing. His pickaxe was down to half durability, the iron head wearing thin. But he didn't slow down. He couldn't.

Clink.

The sound was different. Higher-pitched. Cleaner.

Pick froze.

"Everyone stop," he said quietly.

He broke the block in front of him. There, embedded in the deepslate like a star in the night sky, was a cluster of light-blue gems. Diamonds. Three of them, nestled together, their facets catching the torchlight and scattering it across the tunnel walls.

"I—" Pick swallowed. "I found them."

The crew crowded around the narrow tunnel, peering over each other's shoulders. Red let out a low whistle. Stone grinned, the first real smile any of them had seen from him all day.

"Three diamonds," Gear said. "We did it."

"Keep digging," Red said, his voice steady but his hands trembling. "There's more."

They widened the area around the diamond cluster, Pick taking point with his pickaxe while the others kept watch. And then

—

Clink.

Another cluster. Two diamonds this time, deeper in the wall, hidden behind a vein of lapis lazuli.

"That's five," Stone said. "Five diamonds."

"Branch mining works," Pick said, almost to himself. "The math. The spacing. The Y-level. It actually works."

"I never doubted you," Red said. And from the look in his eyes, he meant it.

A hiss echoed from somewhere to their left. Then another. A lava pocket had opened up in the next tunnel over, a river of molten rock spilling across the floor. The heat hit them like a wall.

"Back to the main shaft!" Red shouted. "Move!"

They scrambled through the tunnels, Gear grabbing the last of the torches as they ran. The lava pursued them, but it flowed slowly, lazily, across the deepslate floor.

At the base of the central shaft, Red called for a headcount. "Stone? Brick? Gear? Pick?"

All accounted for. All breathing hard.

"We got the diamonds," Brick said, still panting. "Let's get the hell out of here."

The climb back was brutal. Every muscle ached. Their hunger bars were flashing red, hearts thumping warning beats. But nobody complained. Not even Brick.

When they finally broke the surface, the sun was setting over the plains. The base's chimney smoke rose against an orange sky. A chicken wandered past, clucking indifferently.

Red held the five diamonds in his palm, turning them over. They were flawless—deep blue with that telltale shimmer that made every miner's heart skip.

"An enchantment table needs two diamonds in the recipe, plus four obsidian and a book," he said. "These five diamonds give us two for the table, one for the pickaxe, one for a sword, and one for luck."

"One for luck," Stone repeated, nodding.

Back in the base, Gear started cooking the last of their food while Pick sketched out a design for an enchantment room—a 15x15 space with bookshelves arranged in the optimal L-shape pattern for maximum level thirty enchantments.

"We'll need thirty bookshelves total," Pick said, calculating on his fingers. "That's ninety leather and two hundred and seventy paper. But once it's built, we can enchant at level thirty from a single lapis charge."

Red laid the diamonds on the crafting table. The glowstone lamps seemed to burn brighter, reflecting off the gems.

"Tomorrow," Red said, "we build the enchantment table. Tonight..."

He looked at the crew—dirty, exhausted, bruised from creeper encounters and scraping through deepslate tunnels.

"Tonight, we celebrate."

Brick pulled out a jug of suspicious stew that Gear had brewed from brown mushrooms and a dandelion. "To Pick's crazy tunnel math," he said, raising the jug.

"To branch mining," the crew echoed.

And somewhere beneath them, at Y-level negative fifty-eight, the tunnels they'd carved sat in the darkness—the first of many in what would become one of the most successful mining operations in the Overworld.

But that's another story.

MINING TIPS FROM THIS CHAPTER:

1. **Y =-58 is the optimal level** for diamond mining in modern Minecraft (1.18+). Diamonds generate most frequently in deepslate layers between Y=-64 and Y=-16, with the highest concentration at Y=-58.
2. **Branch mining at 2x1 tunnels every 3 blocks** maximizes exposed faces per block mined. Each tunnel reveals four blocks per meter: two walls, one ceiling, one floor. The three-block gap means you see every possible diamond vein without digging unnecessary stone.
3. **Place torches on one side of the tunnel only** (e.g., right wall) to always know which direction leads out. If torches are on your right going in, they'll be on your left coming back.
4. **Bring extra shields and food.** Explosions and starvation are the #1 and #2 killers in deep mining. One shield per person is not enough.

5. **S**upport your tunnels with pillars every 3-4 blocks in deepslate areas if you're disturbing large volumes of stone. Cave-ins are rare but catastrophic.

Chapter 6: The Enchantment

The morning after the diamond haul, Red stood in the center of the base with a piece of charcoal and a flat slab of stone. The crew sat around him nursing bowls of mushroom stew, still sore from the deepslate grind.

"Five diamonds," Red said, tapping the slab. "That's our ticket out of the iron age. But a diamond pickaxe without enchantment is like a car without fuel—looks good, goes nowhere."

Gear was already sketching on his own slab, a coil of redstone dust serving as a paperweight. "The enchantment table needs two diamonds, four obsidian, and a book. Obsidian we have—that lava pool we found last week gave us six blocks. Book's easy: paper and leather."

"I've been working on the room design." Gear flipped the slab around. "Optimal enchanting goes up to level thirty. That requires fifteen bookshelves arranged in a specific pattern—one block of air between the table and the bookshelves."

"Fifteen bookshelves is a lot of cows," Brick groaned.

"Forty-five leather to be exact," Pick said, not looking up from his own calculations. "Plus two hundred and seventy paper. That's

about sixteen sugarcane harvested and replanted three times, assuming a fully grown stalk yields one paper worth of sugar."

Red cracked his knuckles. "Stone and Brick, you're on leather duty. There's a plains biome three blocks east—cows as far as the eye can see. Gear, you're with me. We need sugarcane, and we need string."

"String?" Stone raised an eyebrow.

Red smiled. "The enchanting setup isn't complete without a bow. And bows need string. I've got eyes on an abandoned mineshaft under the taiga. Word is there's a cave spider spawner down there."

Stone set his bowl down. "Cave spiders. You're talking about the tiny green ones that poison you and move like greased lightning."

"Poison won't kill you by itself," Red said. "But it'll drop you to half a heart and leave you helpless. The real danger is the swarms. They spawn fast, they're hard to hit, and once you're poisoned, you panic."

"Lovely," Brick muttered.

The plains stretched out under a brilliant blue sky, tall grass swaying in the breeze. Stone and Brick crested a hill and spotted the herd—at least thirty cows dotting the landscape, their brown-and-white hides warm in the morning light.

"Thirty cows," Brick said, hefting his stone sword. "We need forty-five leather. Plus extras for mistakes."

"You're not going to kill them all, are you?"

"Not if we're smart." Stone pulled out a bucket. "First, we breed them. Get the herd bigger, then harvest the extras. Sustainable."

Brick looked confused. "Breed them? With what?"

Stone held up a handful of wheat. "You've been living under a block? Cows love wheat. Two cows with wheat makes a baby cow. Baby cow grows up, gives leather. It's basic economics."

For the next hour, Stone played shepherd—luring cows with wheat, leading them into a temporary pen he'd built from fence posts, and expanding the herd until nearly fifty cattle milled about, mooing in protest.

Brick handled the, uh, *harvesting* end of things. He wasn't gentle, but he was efficient. By noon, they had forty-eight pieces of leather stacked in Stone's inventory, plus enough steak to feed the crew for a week.

"Not bad," Stone said, tossing a raw steak to Brick. "You're almost useful."

"Almost?" Brick caught the steak one-handed. "I'm the muscle. You're the brains. Together we're a whole operation."

Meanwhile, Red and Gear had found the river. Sugarcane grew along its banks in tall green stalks, their tips brushing against the surface of the water. Gear harvested methodically, cutting each stalk at the base and leaving the bottom block to regrow.

"Forty-five stalks minimum," Gear counted. "That's a lot of planting."

"We'll set up a farm," Red said. "Sugarcane grows fast—one block every eighteen minutes if it's planted on sand or dirt next to water. A small patch with forty-five stalks in a checkerboard pattern will yield a full harvest in three Minecraft days."

Red pulled out a shovel and began digging a trench next to the river. "Water source block here. Dirt rows along the edge. Four rows of twelve should give us forty-eight plants. By the time we're back from the mineshaft, we'll have enough for all nine bookshelves worth of paper."

They built the farm in under an hour—a neat grid of tilled dirt beside the river, each row fed by a water channel. Gear planted the sugarcane stalks carefully, spacing them out for maximum growth.

"Done," Gear said, standing back to admire his work. "Three days and we're golden."

"Good. Now for the fun part."

The entrance to the abandoned mineshaft was a hole in the ground, half-hidden by vines and dirt. Red went first, torch in one hand, iron sword in the other. Gear followed, his shield raised and a bucket of milk sloshing at his belt.

"Milk?" Gear asked.

"Cave spiders poison you," Red said. "Milk clears the poison. We drink it, we don't die."

The mineshaft opened up into a vast network of wooden supports and narrow tunnels. The wood was rotten in places, creaking under its own weight. Cobwebs stretched across the corridors, sticky and thick.

"Remember the rule," Red whispered. "Torches on the right going in."

They moved deeper. The air grew stale. Then, from somewhere ahead, a faint *click-clack* echoed through the tunnels. Then another. Then a dozen.

Red held up a fist—*stop*.

Around the corner, the tunnel opened into a large chamber. And in the center, wrapped in a cage of cobwebs, sat a spawner—its iron bars flickering with a faint purple glow, miniature cave spiders rotating around it like satellites around a dark star.

"That's it," Gear breathed.

"Spawners only activate when a player is within sixteen blocks," Red said. "So right now we're safe. The moment we cross that threshold—"

A spider dropped from the ceiling. It was tiny—smaller than a regular spider, with a greenish-blue tint and eyes that glowed an angry red. It landed on Gear's shoulder and bit down.

Gear screamed. The venom hit instantly—his vision blurred, health bar dropping to a single row of half-hearts, green poison hearts appearing on his screen. He stumbled, dropping his torch.

"Drink the milk!" Red shouted, slicing the spider in two with his sword.

Gear fumbled for the bucket, chugging the milk in desperate gulps. The poison cleared. His health stopped draining. But already, more spiders were coming—pouring out of cracks in the walls, dropping from the ceiling, crawling through the cobwebs.

"We're in range of the spawner!" Red yelled. "We need to break it!"

The narrow corridor became a nightmare. Every swing of Red's sword hit a spider—but two more took its place. They were fast, relentless, their bites landing faster than he could drink milk.

Gear grabbed a torch and held it like a weapon. "Spiders hate light! Push forward!"

They advanced, step by agonizing step, clubbing and slashing through the swarm. Red caught a bite on his arm—the poison surged again. He drank. Another bite to the leg. He drank again. His milk supply was running out.

"Five blocks!" Gear shouted. "Four! Three!"

Red lunged for the spawner, his iron sword raised. A spider latched onto his back, fangs sinking into his shoulder. He gritted his teeth, swung—

CRUNCH.

The spawner shattered. Its bars crumbled, the purple glow flickering out. The remaining spiders, freed from their spawning source, scattered into the darkness.

Red collapsed against the wall, breathing hard. "Tell me... you got the string."

Gear held up a bundle of white strands, pulled from the webs. "Twenty-three pieces. More than enough for a bow."

Red laughed, a raw, exhausted sound. "Good. Now help me up. We've got an enchantment table to build."

Back at the base, the crew assembled.

Stone and Brick had forty-eight leather. The sugarcane farm had yielded its first full harvest—two hundred and eighty paper, enough for nine bookshelves and change. Gear had his string, and Red had the obsidian and diamonds.

Gear laid out the schematic for the enchanting room. "The table goes in the center. Bookshelves go in a ring around it—but not right next to it. There has to be a one-block gap of air between the table and the bookshelf. And they need to be at the same height or one block higher."

"So a horseshoe," Stone said.

"Exactly." Gear drew a U-shape on the floor. "Fifteen bookshelves total. Three rows of three on the left, three rows of three on the right, and three rows of three across the back. The front stays open so you can walk in and use the table."

"This is for Level 30 enchantments," Pick said, his eyes gleaming. "The most powerful you can get without a secondary setup."

They built the bookshelves first. Red took the diamonds and obsidian and crafted the enchantment table at the crafting table—two diamonds on either side of the top row, a diamond in the center, obsidian filling the bottom row and the book at the top

center. The table hummed as it took shape, a purple glow emanating from its surface.

"Beautiful," Red whispered.

They placed it in the center of the room, exactly where Gear's schematic showed. Then came the bookshelves—fifteen of them, arranged in the perfect horseshoe pattern. When the last one clicked into place, the enchantment table pulsed, runes swirling across its surface in an ancient script.

"Level thirty," Gear said. "Every enchantment at its maximum potential."

Stone stepped forward. In his hand, he held the diamond pickaxe—the one they'd earned in the deepslate tunnels, forged from the gems Pick had mined at Y=-58.

"This is what it's for," Stone said. "All of it. The branch mining, the cows, the sugarcane, the spider pit... this."

He placed the pickaxe in the left slot of the enchantment table. The table hummed louder, the runes spinning faster. In the right slot, he placed three lapis lazuli—the fuel for the enchantment.

Three options appeared.

Stone scanned them: Efficiency III, Unbreaking III. And as a bonus enchantment—Fortune I.

"The pickaxe already has Efficiency II from the anvil," Red said. "We can combine them. Efficiency III plus Unbreaking III plus Fortune I. That's a god-tier pick."

"How?" Stone asked.

Gear pointed to the anvil they'd placed in the corner—a massive block of iron with a flat top. "You enchant the pickaxe. Then you repair it and upgrade it with the anvil. The anvil costs experience levels, but the result is a legendary tool."

Stone selected the enchantment. The table spun, a shower of purple particles raining down. When it stopped, the pickaxe glowed with a faint, humming energy—enchanted, alive, *powerful*.

Efficiency III. Unbreaking III.

He picked it up. It felt different—lighter, more responsive. He swung it at the cobblestone wall of the base, and the block shattered in a single hit.

"Whoa," Brick said.

"Efficiency III makes it three times faster than an unenchanted diamond pickaxe," Pick said. "And Unbreaking III means it'll last roughly four times longer before breaking. With Mending—if we ever find it—this tool will never die."

Stone cradled the pickaxe like a newborn. "This changes everything."

Red nodded. "That's the idea."

He walked to the map on the wall—the one with X's and question marks. He uncapped his charcoal and drew a large circle in the unexplored territory to the east.

"What's that?" Gear asked.

Red didn't answer immediately. He studied the map, his eyes narrowing.

"Something bigger."

The crew exchanged glances. The room fell silent, the only sound the hum of the enchantment table and the faint crackle of the glowstone lanterns.

"How much bigger?" Stone asked.

Red turned, a glint in his eye. "Stronghold bigger."

The word hung in the air like a thundercloud. Strongholds. The End Portal. The Dragon.

"Find a stronghold," Red said, "and we find the End Portal. Find the End Portal..."

"We fight the Ender Dragon," Gear finished.

Stone looked down at his new pickaxe, the enchantment runes pulsing with purple light. It was the most powerful tool he'd ever held.

And suddenly, it felt like not enough.

ENCHANTING TIPS FROM THIS CHAPTER:

1. **T**he optimal Level 30 enchanting setup requires exactly 15 bookshelves arranged with a one-block gap of air between the bookshelves and the enchantment table. The most space-efficient pattern is a horseshoe: 5 bookshelves on the left, 5 on the right, 5 across the back, with the front open.
2. **B**ookshelves cost one book and three planks each.
Books cost three paper and one leather. So 15 book-

shelves = 15 books = 45 leather and 270 paper (from ~90 sugarcane stalks grown over three harvests).

3. **S** **pawners activate within 16 blocks** of a player. When approaching a spawner room, prepare with milk buckets (clears poison), light sources, and area-of-effect weapons.
4. **M** **ilk clears status effects.** In cave spider fights, always carry a bucket of milk to instantly clear poison. Drink it, don't save it.
5. **T** **he anvil combines enchantments**, repairs items, and renames them. Combining an Efficiency II pick with an Efficiency III book costs levels but yields a superior tool. Plan your upgrades carefully.
6. **T** **he Enchantment Table + Anvil + Grindstone** forms the complete enchanting system. The grindstone removes enchantments to recover some experience from unwanted tools.

Chapter 7: Stronghold Run

"Fate points down."

The briefing table was covered in materials — blaze rods still warm from the Nether, a pouch of ender pearls pulsing with captured void, and a single shimmering Eye of Ender glowing at the center.

Stone picked up a pearl. Colder than it should be. Like holding a piece of the night sky.

"What are these for?"

Red stood at the head of the table. There was a weight in his eyes that Stone hadn't seen before.

"The big job," Red said. "The one that sets us up for good."

The crew leaned in. Brick cracked his knuckles. Gear adjusted his goggles. Pick was already taking notes.

"There's a structure buried underground," Red continued. "Ancient. Older than anything on the surface. The strongholds were built by something that came before. And at the heart of every stronghold — a portal."

"A portal to where?" Gear asked.

"The End."

Silence. The name echoed off the stone walls. A dimension of void and shadow. A dragon that ruled the sky. A place nobody on this server had ever raided successfully.

"You're talking about the dragon dimension," Pick said flatly.

"Nobody's ever had this crew," Red said.

Gear shifted. "First we find the stronghold. That's the hard part."

Red tossed the Eye to Pick. "You're up. Tell us how we triangulate this thing."

Pick spread a map across the table, coordinates marked in precise handwriting. "Eyes of Ender are simple. You throw one, it floats toward the stronghold for about twelve blocks, then either drops or breaks. You follow the direction, throw again, adjust course."

"How many throws?" Stone asked.

"Depends on distance. Some pop on impact — maybe one in five. The survivors, you pick up and reuse." Pick pulled out a notebook of equations. "I've calculated the optimal pattern. We find the angle from two different throw locations, plot the intersection on the map, and get the stronghold coordinates within twenty blocks."

"Twenty blocks of error's a lot," Brick said.

"Not when the structure can span a hundred blocks underground."

Gear counted materials. "We've got twelve blaze rods from the Nether run. Each makes two blaze powder. Each powder plus one pearl makes an Eye. Pearls are the bottleneck — we've got six."

"Six Eyes," Red said. "The portal needs twelve. We'd better find that stronghold fast."

The Hunt Begins

They set out at dawn. Plains gave way to dark oak forests, rivers cutting through the landscape like silver veins. Pick threw the first Eye at the edge of a sunflower field.

It launched with a soft *whoosh*, trailing sparkling particles, oriented itself, and drifted southeast.

"Got a heading," Pick said, plucking it off the grass. "Still intact. At least five hundred blocks."

They walked. The sun climbed overhead. Gear marked their coordinates on a scrap of paper while Brick kept watch for mobs that might wander into their path. The Eye led them through two biomes before Pick called for a second throw.

Two hundred blocks later, he tossed again. The Eye soared higher this time, its particle trail longer and brighter before it dropped to the grass and shattered on impact.

"Lost one. Seven left."

The crew exchanged glances. Seven Eyes to find a structure that could be eight hundred blocks out, and twelve needed to open the portal once they reached it.

"Keep going," Red said. "Find the stronghold first."

The third throw led them into a roofed forest where the canopy swallowed the sky. The Eye wove between trunks like a ghost, light filtering through the leaves in scattered beams. At the edge of a clearing, Pick threw the fourth — and a stray skeleton arrow caught it mid-flight. The Eye burst in a shower of green sparks, particles raining down like tears.

Pick stared at the drifting remnants. "That's not possible."

Brick doubled over laughing. "The skeleton shot your Eye!"

"A skeleton cannot target a thrown item!" Pick's face was reddening. "That violates entity targeting rules!"

"Tell that skeleton."

The skeleton stood at the edge of the clearing, bow still raised, skull tilted as if it knew exactly what it had done. Stone put an arrow through its ribcage. The bones clattered to the forest floor.

Gear counted quietly. "Five Eyes left."

The laughter died.

At the eight hundred block mark, Pick threw the fifth Eye. It rose thirty blocks into the air, hung suspended, and then fell straight down, burying itself in the dirt.

"We're here," Pick said. "Stronghold's directly below us."

Stone looked at the grass beneath his boots. Somewhere in the dark, an ancient structure waited.

"Dig."

The Stronghold

Gear found the first mossy brick at Y=42. The air that rose from the broken ceiling was stale and cold — the breath of centuries.

Red dropped first, sword in one hand, torch in the other. "It's huge. I can't even see the end."

The stronghold was a maze. Corridors branched in every direction — some ending in sudden drops, others opening into vast chambers. Cracked stone bricks. Moss-covered walls. Cobwebs draped the ceilings like burial shrouds. Their torches cast shadows that made every corner look like it held something waiting.

"This place is older than anything I've ever seen," Gear whispered. The enchanted redstone lines on his chestplate reflected the flickering torchlight.

"How do we find the portal?" Brick asked.

"Portal rooms sit at the end of main corridors," Pick said. "Pick a direction, mark every turn. If we hit a dead end, backtrack."

"And the silverfish," Stone added.

"The what?"

The wall next to Brick's head *cracked*. A block of mossy stone split open and a gray segmented creature burst out, skittering up the wall. It bit at Brick's arm before he could react.

Brick crushed it against the wall. More blocks cracked. More silverfish poured out — a dozen, two dozen, their chittering filling the corridor like a living wave.

"RUN!"

They sprinted through three corridors, a spiral staircase, and a flooded intersection before the silverfish gave up, retreating into their stone shells. The crew collapsed against a wall, gasping.

"I hate this place," Brick said.

The Library

They found the library by accident.

Stone had been marking their path — torches on the right wall only — when the corridor opened into a cavernous room, two stories high, filled with bookshelves stretching into darkness. A dry fountain sat in the center, its basin thick with dust.

Gear's eyes went wide. "Enchanted books. If any have decent enchantments—"

"We're not here to loot," Red said, though even his voice was softer than usual.

Gear pointed to the far end of the library. Behind a curtain of cobwebs, a doorway led into a smaller chamber.

They crossed the library slowly. The doorway opened, and there it was.

The End Portal.

Twelve blocks of ornate dark stone arranged in a circle, each topped with a recessed slot. The center was nothing but blackness — an absence so complete that looking at it felt like falling.

"Twelve slots," Pick said quietly. "We've got five Eyes."

Red's jaw tightened. "We need more pearls."

They stood in silence, staring at the empty frame. So close. Seven short.

"Endermen," Stone said finally.

The Ender Pearl Hunt

Night had fallen over the surface. A new moon. Perfect conditions.

They didn't have to wait long. A tall figure stood motionless on the plain, its long limbs silhouetted against the stars, purple eyes glowing.

"Don't look at it," Gear cautioned. "Look at its feet."

Stone drew his sword. The Enderman turned its head. Purple eyes locked on.

It screamed — a sound like tearing reality — and teleported behind him. Claws swung. Stone rolled, came up swinging, caught the Enderman's leg. It shrieked and teleported again.

Brick threw a snowball. It hit the Enderman square in the chest. The creature turned, furious, teleporting toward him — right into the path of Pick's arrow.

The Enderman dissolved, leaving a single pulsing ender pearl on the grass.

"Seven to go."

The hunt lasted hours. They fought in shifts — two engaging, two resting, one watching for more spawns. Endermen came in ones and twos, sometimes three at a time, each fight a frantic dance of breaking eye contact and striking at the last second.

Stone took a hit to the ribs that cracked his chestplate and sent him sprawling. Brick dragged him back by the collar while Gear and Pick delivered a volley of arrows to the Enderman's torso. Gear circled around, sword drawn, forcing the creature into a line of fire. Pick's arrow punched through its shoulder, and the Enderman dissolved into particles, another pearl hitting the dirt.

"That one almost had your name on it," Brick said, hauling Stone upright.

"Almost."

By the time the moon reached its zenith, they had seven fresh pearls.

Pick worked by torchlight, crushing blaze rods into powder, mixing each portion with an ender pearl until they shimmered green. "Twelve Eyes of Ender. Ready to go."

The Activation

Gear moved around the frame methodically, placing each Eye into its slot with the care of a craftsman.

Slot one. Slot two. Slot three.

The Eyes clicked into place, each emitting a soft hum that grew louder. The blackness in the center began to ripple — not filling with light, but *changing*, like water disturbed by something beneath.

Slot seven. Slot eight. Slot nine.

The crew gathered around. Stone felt the hum in his teeth. Brick stood with his axe ready. Pick had an arrow nocked. Gear's hands were steady as he placed the final Eyes.

Slot eleven. Slot twelve.

The frame erupted.

Purple light exploded from the center — not outward, but inward, as if the void was being consumed by energy. The blackness swirled and *opened*. A gateway. Dark purple, shimmering, pulsing like a distant nebula.

"Portal's active," Gear said, stepping back. "I actually can't believe this worked."

Stone stared into the rift. Beyond it, he knew, was another world. An island of end stone floating in an endless void. Obsidian pillars. A dragon circling the sky.

"Is everyone ready?" Red asked. He looked at each of them in turn. "Because once we step through, there's no coming back until it's done."

Brick cracked his neck. "Didn't walk eight hundred blocks and get bitten by silverfish to chicken out now."

"I've got enough arrows to fill the void," Pick said.

Gear lit a fresh torch. "I'll keep us out of the dark."

Stone met Red's eyes and nodded once.

The purple light cast deep shadows across Red's face. He turned to the portal, one hand reaching toward its surface.

"Alright," Red said. "Who's coming with me?"

Chapter 8: End Battle

The portal stood before them like a wound in the world.

It wasn't like the Nether portals—those were rough-hewn, crackling things, built from desperation and obsidian. This was something else. A of smooth end stone, twelve eyes of ender staring out from their sockets, each one holding a glint of something terrible and ancient. The portal's surface shimmered, not with fire but with a starfield—deep, infinite black speckled with pinpricks of cold white light.

The crew stood in the ruined stronghold, torches flickering against centuries-old stone. The air tasted of dust and ozone.

"So this is it," Gear said, adjusting the straps on his chest plate. His voice echoed in the chamber.

"This is it," Stone confirmed.

Red was already stepping forward, sword drawn. "Enough talk. Let's finish this."

Brick cracked his knuckles. "Finally. I've been waiting to punch something that thinks it's a god."

Pick surveyed the portal with a scholar's eye, his enchanted pickaxe resting across his shoulders. "The End. The dragon's domain. Dimension of void and hunger and—"

"Dude," Brick cut in. "You're freaking me out."

"Good," Pick said flatly. "You should be."

Stone took a breath. Five years of mining, fighting, building, surviving. Five years of chasing rumors about this place—the farthest corner of existence, the final biome, the boss at the end of everything. He looked at his crew. Red, the blade. Brick, the hammer. Gear, the brains. Pick, the map.

They were ready. They had to be.

Stone stepped through the portal.

The world inverted.

There was no transition, no tunnel of light, no burning heat like the Nether. One moment Stone was standing on stone bricks in a stronghold. The next, he was falling.

Not falling down. Falling *into*.

The End was a void of black shot through with distant stars, so vast and empty that Stone's brain couldn't process the scale. There was no up. No down. Just a sickening sense of *space*—more space than any dimension was supposed to have.

Then he hit something solid.

His feet found purchase on a floating island of end stone—a pale, bleached rock that looked like the bones of a dead world. Behind him, the portal ripped open and spat out the rest of the crew in a tangle of limbs and curses.

Red landed in a crouch, sword already out. "Where—what—"

Brick landed flat on his back, groaning. "I changed my mind. I don't like this."

Gear scrambled upright, water bucket somehow still clutched in his hand. "Everyone okay? Sound off."

"Here," Stone said.

"Here," Pick said, already scanning the horizon—what little there was of it.

The island they stood on was a small one, no bigger than a city block. End stone stretched out in a ring around them, dotted with pillars of obsidian that rose like black fingers reaching for nothing. Beyond the edge of the island, there was nothing. Just void. Infinite, star-flecked, hungry nothing.

And above them, circling, was the dragon.

It was enormous. Stone had seen pictures in old stronghold libraries, crude drawings scratched into the margins of ancient texts. None of them did it justice. The End Dragon was black as obsidian, with scales that seemed to drink the light around them. Its wings spanned the width of the entire island, each membrane translucent and ribbed with purple veins that pulsed with a sickly glow. Its eyes were the same violet-white as the portal's starfield—ancient, knowing, and utterly without mercy.

It was watching them.

It had been watching them since the moment they arrived.

The dragon let out a sound—not a roar, not a screech, but something low and resonant that vibrated through the end stone

and up through Stone's boots. A bass note that felt like it came from the bottom of the world.

"The End," Pick whispered, his voice barely audible, "is the place where the fabric of reality ends. It's a closed system. Finite. There is nothing beyond this except the void."

"Awesome pep talk," Red said through gritted teeth. "Now what?"

The dragon broke its circle and dove.

"Move!"

Stone's shout cut through the paralysis. The crew scattered as the dragon hit the island like a meteor, its claws gouging trenches through the end stone. The impact sent a shockwave that nearly threw Gear off the edge—he caught himself at the last second, fingers white-knuckled on the rim of the island, his legs dangling over the void.

"Gear!" Stone sprinted toward him, but Gear waved him off.

"I got it!"

Gear twisted, looked down into that endless fall, and made a choice. He dropped his water bucket just below his feet, and in the split second before it fell into the void, the water splashed out, forming a floating pool. He let go, landed in the water with a splash, and scrambled back onto solid ground.

"The bucket trick," Pick said, impressed. "Always works."

"I saw it in a video," Gear panted.

The dragon was already climbing back into the sky, banking hard for another pass. This time, Stone saw what he hadn't noticed in the chaos—towers. Obsidian pillars ringing the island, maybe ten in total, each one topped with a glowing crystal that hovered in a cage of bars.

"Pick! The crystals!"

Pick followed his gaze, eyes widening. "End Crystals. They heal the dragon. We have to destroy them first, every single one, or we can't kill it."

"Then that's the mission," Stone said. "Crystals first. We work our way around the island. Red, you're on dragon watch—keep it busy. Brick, you're on crystal duty. Gear, support. Pick, navigation."

"What about you?" Red asked.

"I'm everywhere," Stone said. "Let's move."

The first crystal was on a pillar twenty blocks high—a spire of obsidian with a cage at the top, the crystal pulsing with a warm golden light that seemed almost peaceful. It was a trap. Everything in the End was a trap.

Brick charged the base of the pillar and started climbing, hands and feet finding holds in the rough obsidian. Above him, the dragon came around for another pass, and Red met it—not head-on, because nobody was stupid enough to fight an End Dragon head-on—but with arrows.

Red had always been good with a bow. She'd spent countless nights on watch, picking off creepers before they could get close, skeleton archers before they could line up their shots. This was different. The dragon moved with a predator's grace, twisting in the air to dodge her arrows, each one pinging off its scales like pebbles off armor.

"I'm just annoying it!" Red shouted.

"That's the plan!" Stone called back. "Keep it annoyed!"

Brick reached the top of the pillar, grabbed the cage bars, and pulled himself up. The crystal hovered just beyond his reach, protected by the bars. He grabbed his pickaxe and swung.

The first strike sent a crack through the crystal, and the whole island seemed to shudder. The dragon screamed—a real scream this time, high and piercing, full of fury.

"You woke it up!" Gear yelled.

"Good!" Brick swung again, and the crystal shattered in an explosion of light and sound.

A column of pure white energy shot up from the pillar, piercing the void. The dragon recoiled, banking away from the light, and for a brief moment, the crew had room to breathe.

"One down," Pick counted. "Nine to go. Move to the next."

But as Brick dropped from the pillar, the dragon's tail caught him mid-air.

It was pure bad luck. The dragon wasn't even aiming for him—it was turning to avoid the light pillar, and its tail swept through the space Brick was falling through. The impact sounded like a

block of stone hitting wet dirt. Brick was sent spinning, tumbling over the edge of the island, his body cartwheeling toward the void.

"BRICK!"

Stone didn't think. He didn't plan. He just moved, pulling out the ender pearl he'd been carrying since the stronghold—the one Pick had insisted on, the one he'd called "the panic button."

He threw it.

The pearl arced over the void, trailing purple particles, and Stone felt the familiar lurch as his body dissolved and reformed. He appeared in mid-air, falling—no, *falling*—and then his hands closed around Brick's armor.

Stone threw his weight, twisting them both back toward the island. They hit the edge hard, Stone's legs dangling over the void, Brick lying dazed on the end stone.

"You—" Brick coughed, spitting purple particles from the teleport. "You pearl-clutched me?"

"Don't make a habit of it," Stone said, hauling himself back up. "That was my only one."

Brick looked at him with something between gratitude and disbelief. "You're insane."

"Get the next crystal."

They fell into a rhythm.

Red kept the dragon busy, her bow singing as she peppered it with arrows from every angle. She was a dancer in the chaos,

moving with a grace that Stone had always admired but never understood. The dragon chased her, breathed purple fire at her, tried to pin her with its claws, but she was always a half-step ahead.

Gear became the crew's safety net. He set up water drops at the base of each pillar, creating emergency pools for anyone who fell. He placed torches—defiant little beacons of light—at intervals around the island, pushing back the void. He was the one who noticed that the endermen were starting to gather.

"We've got company!" Gear shouted, pointing.

They were coming out of nowhere—tall, slender figures with long arms and eyes that burned violet. The endermen had been watching from the darkness, and now they moved in, drawn by the chaos, their teleports popping them across the island in unpredictable bursts.

"Don't look at them!" Pick shouted, but it was too late. Brick, still aching from his near-death, made eye contact with one.

The enderman screamed—a sound like tearing reality—and charged.

Brick met it with his fists. "COME ON THEN!"

The fight was messy. The endermen hit hard and moved faster than anything that tall had a right to. They teleported behind you, hit you from angles you weren't covering, and their touch burned. But the crew had been fighting endermen since their first week in the world. They knew the rhythm.

Pick, armed with experience and a sharp eye, called out positions. "Behind you, Red—left, left—Gear, watch the—"

A chorus of explosions cut him off.

Stone looked up. The dragon was healing. The last five crystals were still intact, and the dragon had swept back over one of them, bathing in its light, and the cracks from their earlier damage were sealing themselves.

"It's healing!" Gear shouted.

"We see it!" Stone grabbed Brick's shoulder. "Faster. We need to go faster."

They pushed. Brick shattered the second crystal while Red held off three endermen at once. Gear took out the third with his bow, a lucky shot that threaded through the cage bars. Stone climbed a pillar himself for the fourth, ignoring the burning in his arms and the terrifying emptiness below him.

Each destroyed crystal sent another column of light into the void, and the dragon grew more frantic. It stopped circling. It started hunting.

The fifth crystal fell. Then the sixth. The seventh.

The island was a battlefield now. The end stone was cracked and cratered from dragon fire and combat. Torches lay scattered, some still burning, some stomped out. The crew was battered and exhausted. Red had a gash across her arm. Brick was limping. Gear had gone through half his inventory. Pick had lost his pickaxe somewhere—he was fighting with a sword now, and he wasn't good with a sword.

But the dragon was dying.

It had stopped going for the crystals to heal itself. The remaining three pulsed in the distance, but the dragon was too weak, too desperate. It knew.

"You're losing!" Red taunted, blood streaming down her arm. "You hear me? WE'RE TAKING YOU DOWN!"

The dragon snarled and dove, but it was slower now. Predictable. Red sidestepped, and Brick met it with the full force of his enchanted diamond axe.

The axe bit deep into the dragon's wing joint, and the creature howled. Purple blood—if it could be called blood—spattered across the end stone, hissing and evaporating.

"Two more crystals!" Pick shouted. "Just two more!"

They took the eighth together, all of them laying into the pillar at once, Brick's axe shattering the bars while Stone destroyed the crystal with his sword. The light column erupted, and the dragon crashed into the end stone, its legs giving out.

One crystal left.

The ninth stood at the far end of the island, the tallest of the pillars, its crystal burning brighter than the rest. The dragon had dragged itself there, coiling around the base of the pillar, guarding it.

"It knows," Pick said quietly. "That's the last one."

"Then we take it," Stone said.

"How?" Gear asked. "It's right there. It'll kill anyone who gets close."

Stone looked at his crew. Battered, bleeding, exhausted. Five people standing on a rock at the end of the universe, staring down a dying god. They shouldn't have made it this far. By every logic, they should have fallen into the void hours ago.

But they were still standing.

"Everyone at once," Stone said. "Full assault. Red, you're on arrows. Brick, you're on the crystal. Gear, Pick—keep the endermen off us. I'll keep the dragon busy."

"That's suicide," Gear said.

"Probably," Stone agreed. "Let's go."

They hit the ninth pillar like a wave.

Red's arrows flew first, sinking into the dragon's flank. It roared and turned, and in that moment, Stone was there, sword flashing, drawing its attention. He danced around its claws, its breath, its fury, buying seconds—precious seconds—for Brick to climb.

Brick climbed like a man possessed. He ignored the pain in his leg, the blood in his eyes, the sound of the dragon's fury below him. He climbed because his friends were counting on him. Because this was the last one. Because after this, it was over.

The endermen swarmed, and Gear and Pick held the line. Gear threw a splash potion of healing that caught all of them—endermen screamed and recoiled. Pick fought with a borrowed sword, hacking and slashing, not with skill but with pure, stubborn refusal to die.

Brick reached the top.

The crystal glowed, warm and golden and waiting. He grabbed his axe. The dragon screamed below him—a sound that was almost pleading.

"Sorry," Brick said. "Nothing personal."

He swung.

The crystal shattered.

For one perfect moment, everything was silent.

The light column erupted, brighter than all the others combined, and the dragon—the End Dragon, the beast of the void, the final boss at the end of everything—fell.

It crashed to the end stone, wings splayed, and for a moment Stone thought it was dead. But then it moved. It dragged itself to the center of the island, to the portal structure that stood there—a fountain of bedrock, crowned with an exit portal ring.

The dragon perched on the portal, gathering the last of its strength, and it looked at them.

Stone had never seen such hate in a living thing. But he also saw something else. Fear.

The dragon was afraid.

"It's protecting the portal," Pick said. "If it dies on the portal, the exit opens. It's the final stand."

"Then let's give it what it wants," Stone said.

He looked at his crew. Red, bleeding but smiling. Brick, exhausted but ready. Gear, out of resources but still standing. Pick, out of his depth but still fighting.

"Together," Stone said.

They charged.

Red got there first, her sword finding the dragon's throat. Brick followed, axe swinging into its ribcage. Pick stabbed at its wing joint. Gear threw a potion of harming—his last one—directly into its open mouth.

And Stone leaped onto the dragon's back, grabbed a scale, and drove his sword into the base of its skull.

For a moment, the dragon went rigid.

Then it exploded.

The explosion was not fire, not sound, but *light*. Purple particles erupted in every direction, shooting up and out and through everything. A pillar of pure energy punched through the void. The exit portal beneath the dragon's corpse flared to life, spinning purple and hypnotic.

And then the XP came.

It was absurd. More orbs than Stone had ever seen—a waterfall, a flood of experience points that cascaded over them, filling their inventories, healing their wounds, leveling them up in a torrent of white and green and blue.

"WHOA!" Brick shouted, laughing. "WHAT IS THIS?!"

"It's the dragon's experience!" Pick shouted back, his voice giddy. "All of it! All the XP it accumulated over centuries! It's—it's —"

"INHALE!" Red screamed, laughing and coughing at the same time.

They stood in the rain of XP, five broken warriors on a rock in the void, and they laughed. Because it worked. Because they won.

The dragon was dead.

Minutes passed. Hours. Time didn't work the same way in the End.

The XP rain finally stopped, and the crew stood in silence, breathing hard, staring at the exit portal. It spun and hummed, waiting.

The poem began.

It wasn't spoken, not exactly. It appeared in their minds, in their vision, scrolling words of white text against the void:

I see the player you mean. —

Stone blinked. "What is this?"

A dream is all it is. A dream that ends.

"It's the End Poem," Pick whispered, his voice reverent. "I've read about it. It's the game's message to the player. It's... it's for us."

Wake up. The universe is infinite.

The words continued, scrolling through existence, painting meaning across the fabric of reality. Stone read some of it—enough to understand that they were part of something bigger, players in a universe made of code and imagination and purpose.

But he was never good at poetry.

The crew stood together as the poem washed over them, not quite understanding it, not needing to. They had felt it. Every battle, every block placed, every monster fought, every friend made—it all meant something. Even if they couldn't put it into words.

Finally, the poem ended. The text faded. And the exit portal hummed, waiting.

"Alright," Gear said, his voice soft. "Who's first?"

"Together," Stone said.

They stepped through the portal together.

The credits didn't roll. There was no fanfare. They just appeared in their world, in their base, standing around the crafting table like they'd never left. The items in their inventories were real. The ache in their muscles was real. The XP levels glowing on their screens were real.

It had happened.

Red collapsed onto the floor, staring up at the cobblestone ceiling. "We did it."

The words hung in the air.

"Yeah," Brick said, sitting down heavily beside her. "We did."

Pick leaned against the wall, wiping blood from a cut on his forehead. "The End Dragon. Defeated. By us."

Gear laughed, a hollow, exhausted sound. "I almost fell into the void. Multiple times. Like, way more times than I'd like to admit."

"You did fall into the void," Stone said, a tired smile crossing his face. "You just caught yourself with a water bucket."

"See? That's skill."

They laughed, and it was the best sound Stone had heard in days. They laughed because they were alive. Because the worst was over. Because they had done the thing nobody in their world had ever done.

But the laughter faded, and the silence that followed was heavy.

Stone looked around the base—at the chests full of resources, the furnaces still smelting, the bed he hadn't slept in for a week. And for the first time since he could remember, he didn't know what to do next.

"So," Red said, picking herself up off the floor. "What now?"

Stone looked at his crew. His friends. The people who had followed him to the end of the world.

He looked at the chests, the tools, the weapons. The world was still there, outside their little base. The sun still rose and set. Creepers still hissed. Zombies still groaned.

The game wasn't over.

"I don't know," Stone admitted. "There's... there's a lot out there. Things I haven't even thought about. I always thought this was the end."

"It's not the end," Pick said quietly. "It's never the end."

Brick cracked his neck, then his knuckles. "Building projects? I've got ideas. Huge ideas."

Gear was already at the crafting table, pulling out ingredients. "I've got potions to brew. I've got redstone circuits to design. I've got projects that will take years."

Red picked up her sword, ran her thumb along the edge. "There's always more to fight."

Stone looked at them, and something settled in his chest. A quiet certainty.

"Then we keep going," he said. "Tomorrow, we keep going."

The crew of five stood in their base, in the world they had built and saved, and they weren't done.

They were just getting started.

End of Chapter 8

Chapter 9: Wither War

Part I: The Restless

The Ender Dragon was dead. The End gateway portals shimmered in silent testimony to what they'd accomplished. For the first time in weeks, the crew of Build Team Zero sat in their base without a single urgent objective hanging over their heads.

It was driving them insane.

"Pass the potatoes," Red said, not looking up from his inventory screen. He was reorganizing his chests for the fourth time that morning.

"You don't even like potatoes," Stone said from the crafting table, where he was systematically turning stacks of iron into anvils they didn't need.

"Doesn't matter. They need to be sorted."

Gear was tinkering with redstone components, building and dismantling the same comparator clock on loop. Brick was pacing. Pick had mined out an entire chunk of stone for no reason other than that he couldn't sit still.

"We beat the Ender Dragon," Pick said, breaking the silence. "That was supposed to be the end."

"It was an end," Stone replied. "Not *the* end."

"Philosophical. Love it." Red slammed a chest shut. "But I'm losing my mind. We've got full diamond gear. We've got shulker boxes. We've got more enchanted books than the Library of Congress. Now what? Build a nice cottage? Pick flowers?"

Brick snorted. "I'd rather fight another dragon."

"Me too," said Gear, finally looking up from his redstone. "But you can't fight the same dragon twice."

Red was about to reply when his hand brushed against something in his ender chest — a book he'd picked up in the Nether fortress during their blaze rod run. He'd almost forgotten about it. The cover was worn, the pages yellowed. He pulled it out and flipped through it.

Then he stopped.

"Hey. Come look at this."

The others gathered around. The page was covered in rough diagrams — a T-shape pattern made of blocks with strange symbols drawn around it. And at the bottom, in jagged charcoal script, three words:

THE WITHER PROJECT

"This," Red said slowly, "is a blueprint. An ancient one. From the piglions. Or something older, maybe."

Stone read over his shoulder. "What does it do?"

"Three Wither Skeleton Skulls. Four blocks of Soul Sand. Arranged in a T. You get..." Red's eyes widened. "A boss. The Wither. Supposedly the most dangerous thing in existence."

"More dangerous than the dragon?" Brick asked.

"Different kind of dangerous. The dragon flies. The Wither *destroys*."

Silence fell over the room. Then Pick grinned.

"One more job."

Part II: Back to Hell

The Nether portal flared to life, its purple surface rippling like water. On the other side lay the crimson forest they'd grown so familiar with during their blaze runs. But the fortress — a sprawling network of dark stone bridges and corridors — wasn't in the crimson forest. It was somewhere deeper, somewhere worse.

"Everyone stocked?" Stone asked, adjusting his shield. "Fire resistance potions?"

"Two full stacks," Gear confirmed.

"Golden apples?"

"Sixteen."

"Sword sharpness?"

"Five," Brick said, holding up his diamond blade. "We're ready."

"What nobody's asking," Red said, stepping through the portal, "is how long this is going to take. Because Wither Skeletons don't exactly drop their skulls on command."

He wasn't kidding.

The fortress was massive — bridges spanning across lava lakes, corridors twisting into darkness, spawners rattling in the depths. But the wither skeletons were rare. And the skulls? Those were a one-in-forty drop. Maybe worse.

Hour one was optimistic. The crew cleared three corridors, fought off a dozen blazes, and collected exactly zero skulls.

"Keep going," Stone said. "We knew this wouldn't be easy."

Hour two, Brick almost died.

A wither skeleton caught him from behind while he was fighting a blaze. The blackened arrow struck him square in the back, and the Wither effect — that creeping, starving decay — set in before he could reach for his milk bucket. His health bar shrank. His heart rate spiked.

"Brick! MILK!"

Pick tackled him with a bucket, forcing it into his hands. Brick chugged it as his screen blurred. His health stopped at four hearts.

"I'm fine," he gasped.

"You got hit," Stone said flatly.

"I said I'm fine."

Hour four, Brick almost died again. A misstep on a bridge sent him tumbling into the lava below. He caught the edge of the

stone with his fingernails, his legs burning in the molten rock. Gear grabbed his arm and hauled him up while Pick frantically dumped fire resistance on him.

"I'm starting to think this fortress has it out for me," Brick muttered, his armor smoking.

Hour six. No skulls. The grind was wearing thin.

"This is insane," Gear said, leaning against a nether brick wall. "We've killed over a hundred of these things. Not a single skull."

"The drop rate is rough," Red admitted. "We might need to rethink this."

Pick had been quiet for a while. Now he spoke up. "I've got an idea."

Part III: The Farm

Pick's idea was simple: build a dedicated wither skeleton farm.

"Fortresses have spawn blocks," he explained, clearing a wide platform above the fortress's central bridge. "If we clear out all the other spawn spaces — block off the tunnels, light up the adjacent areas — the game is forced to spawn wither skeletons in the space we've prepared."

"It's called spawn-proofing," Stone said, nodding. "Clever."

"Then we add a killing chamber," Pick continued. "Water streams funnel them to a drop chute. We stand at the bottom and swing. Efficient. Safe."

Brick raised an eyebrow. "Safe for who?"

"Us. Not safe for the wither skeletons."

The construction took two hours. They mined, they placed, they lit up nearby tunnels, they redirected lava flows. By the time they were done, they had a compact, efficient farm — a small platform where wither skeletons would spawn, separated from the crew by a waist-high wall.

The first skull dropped within ten minutes.

"There it is!" Red grabbed it — a blackened bone skull with hollow eye sockets. "One down. Two to go."

The second skull came twenty minutes later. The third took another forty-five.

Brick had a system now — stand, swing, watch for the drop, repeat. It was monotonous. It was boring. But compared to another near-death experience in lava? He'd take boring.

"Got it!" Gear held up the third skull, his voice cracking with exhaustion and excitement. "That's all three."

The crew stared at the skulls — three identical trophies resting in their inventory slots. They'd done it. Hours of grinding, brushes with death, the monotony of the farm. But they had what they needed.

"Now comes the hard part," Stone said quietly.

Part IV: The Summoning

They built the chamber deep underground — a hundred blocks beneath their base, carved into the stone with painstaking

precision. The walls were obsidian. The floor was obsidian. The ceiling was obsidian. If there was a material that could survive the Wither's explosion, this was it.

"Four blocks of soul sand," Red read from the ancient blueprint, his voice echoing in the hollow space. "Bottom row of three. Top row of one. Center block."

Stone placed the soul sand. The T-shape rose from the obsidian floor like an altar.

"Then the skulls," Red continued. "On top of the three bottom blocks."

"Wait," Brick said. "Does it matter who places them?"

"There's no lore on that. But I think..." Red's voice dropped. "I think we all should."

Stone placed the first skull. The air grew heavy.

Gear placed the second. The torchlight flickered.

Pick placed the third. A low rumble vibrated through the stone.

Red stepped forward. The last skull sat in his hand — the center block of the T. He looked at his crew.

"Whatever happens next," he said, "we do this together."

He placed the skull.

For a moment, nothing happened. Then the world *screamed*.

The sky — or what passed for sky a hundred blocks underground — went black. The torches died. The obsidian walls trembled. And in the center of the room, the T-shape began to

collapse inward, the blocks and skulls swirling into a vortex of darkness and purple particles.

Then the explosion.

The Wither erupted into being with a blast that shattered the first layer of obsidian. It was massive — three heads, each with hollow white eyes, a skeletal body wreathed in dark smoke. Its roar shook the very chunk data of the world.

"IT'S HERE!" Brick screamed, barely audible over the cacophony.

The Wither's heads swiveled. Its eye sockets found them. And it *attacked*.

Part V: Chaos

Blue skulls flew in every direction — homing projectiles that detonated on impact like delayed TNT. The first one hit the wall and blew a hole through the obsidian. The second one hit the floor and sent Stone flying.

"I can't see!" Gear shouted, diving behind a pillar.

"Keep moving!" Red yelled back. "Don't let it line up a shot!"

Brick charged. It was stupid. It was brave. It was absolutely insane.

He got two hits in before a blue skull caught him in the chest and launched him across the chamber. His health bar dropped by half. The Wither effect crept in — the blackened veins spreading across his vision.

"Brick, fall back!" Pick fired arrow after arrow at the Wither, but the projectiles seemed to do nothing. "The arrows — they're barely scratching it!"

"Keep firing!" Stone was on his feet again, shield raised, sword ready. "Every hit counts!"

The battle was chaos. The lava they'd placed around the perimeter as a defensive measure was now a hazard — the Wither's explosions sent blocks flying, creating new pathways, destroying their carefully prepared terrain. The crew was scattered. The Wither was relentless.

And then it happened.

The Wither's health dropped to half.

Its body flashed. The dark smoke around it turned into a shimmering white barrier. Its eyes blazed brighter. And a new sound — a high-pitched, piercing scream — filled the chamber.

"It's changing!" Gear shouted.

"IT'S IMMUNE!" Red's voice cracked. "The book said it — at half health — it becomes immune to arrows!"

Pick's bow went slack. "You're joking."

"I'M NOT JOKING!"

The Wither's attacks intensified. The blue skulls came faster. The explosions were bigger. The crew was pinned — scattered, out of position, and now their primary ranged weapon was useless.

Brick looked at his sword. He looked at the Wither. He looked at his friends.

"I guess it's melee time," he said, and charged again.

Part VI: The Breaking Point

It went on for what felt like hours. The obsidian chamber was unrecognizable — craters everywhere, lava spilling through broken walls, the ceiling partially collapsed. The Wither flew through the destruction like a god of annihilation.

Brick hit it, got blown back, got up, hit it again.

Stone coordinated — shouting positions, calling out incoming skulls, keeping the crew from dying in the crossfire.

Gear used the environment — setting up barriers, redirecting the Wither's path, buying precious seconds.

Pick — without his arrows — grabbed a sword and fought beside Brick, their blades flashing in time.

Red ran the skulls. When a Wither skeleton skull dropped from the chaos — a summoned minion of the boss — he grabbed it, pocketed it, and threw himself back into the fight.

"Focus on the body!" Stone shouted. "The heads are armored — hit the torso!"

One by one, the crew closed in. Brick was at half a heart, his armor broken, his sword shattered. He grabbed a replacement from his inventory and kept swinging.

The Wither roared. Its barrier flickered. Its health bar — nearly invisible, nearly gone — hung at the edge of death.

"One more push!" Red screamed. "EVERYONE! NOW!"

The five of them struck as one. Brick's sword. Pick's axe. Stone's critical hit. Gear's sweeping edge. Red's fire aspect.

The Wither convulsed. Its three heads let out a final, deafening scream. And then — silence.

The explosion was soft — a gentle burst of white light that swept through the chamber like a wave. The smoke cleared. The darkness lifted.

And there, floating in the center of the ruined room, was a single black object. Glowing. Pulsing. Beautiful.

The Nether Star.

Nobody moved. Nobody spoke.

Finally, Gear stepped forward. His hand trembled as he picked it up. The star hummed with energy — raw, pure, unfathomable.

"This," Gear said, his voice barely a whisper, "is going to make something INCREDIBLE."

Part VII: The Beacon

Three days later, they stood on the surface, watching Gear work.

The obsidian base was a pyramid. Not a building — an actual pyramid, three layers of obsidian rising from the earth. On top of it, Gear placed the first block. Then the second. Then the third.

The Beacon block — a device of pure glass, obsidian, and the Nether Star — sat at the apex.

"Ready?" Gear asked.

"Ready," the crew said together.

Gear flipped the switch.

A beam of light erupted from the Beacon, punching through the sky, through the clouds, through the build limit itself. It was visible for hundreds of blocks — a column of brilliance connecting earth and heaven.

The crew watched in silence. They were battered, bruised, exhausted, and victorious.

"One more job," Red said, laughing. "We always say that."

"Maybe this time," Stone said, "we actually relax."

Brick snorted. "Relaxing is boring."

"Then you can farm more wither skeletons," Pick said.

"Pass."

Gear was still staring at the Beacon. "You know what this means, right? We've got the star. We can make any effect we want. Speed, strength, regeneration, resistance — all of it. We can build more Beacons. We can build an entire network."

"A network of Beacons?" Stone asked.

"Why not? We've been fighting monsters. Maybe it's time to build something bigger."

The beam of light shone over Build Team Zero's base, a monument to their greatest battle yet. But even as they stood there, proud and exhausted, a thought lingered in the back of each of their minds:

Something bigger is coming.

They just didn't know what.

But the Beacon would be ready.

End of Chapter 9

Chapter 10: The Successful Life

Dawn broke over the mesa in bands of orange and gold.

Stone sat on the obsidian platform that jutted out from the base's highest tower, legs dangling over the edge, a mug of cocoa warming his hands. Below him, the base sprawled across the plateau like a small kingdom—fields of wheat rippling in stripes, carrot and potato patches in neat grids, a row of furnaces that never stopped humming, the massive sorting hall with its rivers of hoppers and chests stretching into the distance. Beacons cast columns of light into the sky: Haste. Speed. Jump Boost. Regeneration. Strength.

He'd stopped counting the blocks. Tens of thousands, probably. Hundreds of thousands? It didn't matter.

What mattered was the first dig.

It hit him sometimes, in quiet moments like this. The memory of a cramped cave, two iron pickaxes between them, torches running low. Sixteen iron ore, smelted into ingots, traded to a librarian villager for four emeralds. He'd felt rich. He'd felt like a king.

Four emeralds.

Now the vault room held thirty-seven shulker boxes of emeralds alone. The iron farm filled a double chest every two hours. They had more diamonds than they'd ever use, more netherite than they could wear. The beacon network alone cost more resources than that first village had ever seen.

Four emeralds.

Stone smiled into his cocoa.

Footsteps scraped on obsidian behind him. He didn't turn.

"You're up early," Red said, settling down beside him. Her boots clinked against the edge. She was already wearing her full netherite armor, because of course she was. Red never relaxed. Not really.

"Could say the same to you."

Red shrugged. "Couldn't sleep. Thinking."

"Dangerous habit."

She snorted. "I've been mapping out the perimeter expansion. The raid farm is good, but the rates could be better if we add a second platform. And I was thinking—there's a deep dark biome about twelve hundred blocks west. The ancient city there is untouched. We could clear it, set up a ward-based security system, maybe build a secondary outpost."

Stone took a slow sip of his cocoa. "You know we don't need any of that, right?"

"I know."

"We've beaten everything. The Ender Dragon. The Wither. Every raid, every trial chamber, every structure within two thousand blocks. We've built everything. We've stored everything. We have more resources than we'll ever need."

"I know."

"So why are you still looking for the next thing?"

Red was quiet for a long moment. The beacon beams shifted as the sun climbed higher, painting the mesa in warmer light.

"Because," she said slowly, "I don't know what to do with *after*."

Stone nodded. He understood. They'd spent so long surviving, then thriving, then conquering. The game had given them goals—kill the dragon, find the ancient city, build the farm, collect the item. And they'd done all of them. Tick every box. The credits had rolled a dozen times over.

But the world hadn't ended when the credits rolled. The sun still rose. The chickens still clucked. And Red, sitting beside him in full netherite with nowhere left to go, looked more lost than she'd ever been in that first dirt hut.

"Maybe," Stone said, "that's the point."

Red looked at him.

"Maybe we're not supposed to win Minecraft. Maybe we're supposed to *live* it."

Down in the main hall, Brick was already at work.

He'd claimed the eastern wing weeks ago, and it was now recognizably his—rough stone walls that he'd refused to replace with polished variants, a half-finished cathedral ceiling that he swore he'd finish "eventually," and a chest room overflowing with blocks he'd mined by hand because "the beacon makes it too fast, I can't feel the stone anymore."

Today he was building a fountain.

Not a useful fountain. Not a functional one. Just a fountain—andesite and calcite and deepslate, water cascading in three tiers, sea lanterns glowing beneath the surface. It was beautiful. It was pointless.

"It's not pointless," Brick said, not looking up as Gear's footsteps echoed through the hall. "Don't even start."

Gear held up both hands. "I didn't say anything."

"You were thinking it."

"I was thinking it looks good."

Brick paused, chisel in hand, and looked at Gear with narrow eyes. "Really?"

"Really. The water flow is clean. The gradient works. The sea lantern timing makes it look like the water's glowing from inside. It's solid work."

Brick grunted and went back to placing blocks. "Took you long enough to say it."

Gear sat on a nearby ledge, cross-legged, watching. He looked tired—not in a bad way, but in the way of someone who'd spent the last several months rewiring the entire world. Redstone ran

through the base like veins through a body. The sorting system processed sixty-four stacks a minute. The automatic farms operated on circadian clocks. The smelter array was so efficient it produced negative fuel—it generated more than it burned.

"Have you slept?" Brick asked.

"I sleep."

"When?"

"Statistically, once every thirty-six hours."

Brick clicked his tongue. "That's not sleep. That's system maintenance."

"Same thing."

They worked in comfortable silence for a while. Brick placing blocks. Gear watching, occasionally offering a technical suggestion on water spread mechanics. The fountain grew, tier by tier, a monument to nothing in particular.

"You ever think about what we do now?" Brick asked eventually.

"The fountain's not going to build itself."

"I mean *now*. As in, the rest of our lives. We've done everything. The dragon's dead. The Wither's dead twice. We've got more farms than we can visit. What's the point of waking up tomorrow?"

Gear considered the question with the seriousness he applied to everything. "The point is that tomorrow exists."

"That's not an answer."

"Yes it is. We build because we can. We automate because we can. We exist because we can. The alternative is staring at a wall until the save file corrupts. I'd rather keep wiring."

Brick laughed—a deep, genuine sound that echoed off the stone walls. "You know, for a redstone nerd who barely talks, you've got more wisdom than you let on."

"I have systemized wisdom. It's more efficient."

Brick shook his head, still smiling, and placed another block.

Pick was in the library.

The library had started as a single bookshelf in a wall. Then two. Then a chest with a few written books. Then a chest room. Then a full wing, three stories tall, with spiral staircases and lecterns and maps on every wall.

Pick was at the central desk, surrounded by open books, quill in hand. On the desk in front of him, a book titled *A Complete Guide to the Overworld, Volume 17* lay open to a page on bee mechanics.

"You're still writing?" Red asked from the doorway.

Pick looked up, slightly startled. "Red. I didn't hear you."

"Clearly. You've got ink on your nose."

Pick rubbed at his nose, smearing it further. Red walked in and sat across from him, picking up one of the finished volumes. *Volume 3: Nether Navigation and Piglin Trade.*

"These are incredible," she said, flipping through the pages. Detailed diagrams. Coordinates. Tips they'd learned the hard way

—like how piglins respect gold boots, and how to navigate basalt deltas without losing your mind.

"Someone should remember," Pick said quietly. "We learned all of this through trial and error. Every death. Every mistake. Every broken pickaxe and blown-up farm. Someone should remember so the next person doesn't have to do it alone."

Red set the book down. "Are you planning to publish?"

"Publish?"

"You know. Leave it somewhere. A spawn point. A village. A book in a chest in the middle of nowhere."

Pick's expression shifted. He hadn't thought of that. "That's... actually a really good idea."

Red grinned. "I have them occasionally."

The alarm went off at noon.

Not a real alarm—Gear's sensor system pinged the base's chat with a notification: *Unknown player detected within 200 blocks. Coordinates marked.*

The crew gathered at the central map room. A dot blinked at the edge of their claimed territory, near the river that bordered their village.

"It's a new player," Gear said, reading the logs. "No armor. Wooden tools. They've punched exactly twelve trees and died twice to zombies."

"We should help them," Pick said immediately.

"It could be a trap," Red said, but her voice lacked conviction. Nobody set traps by spawning naked and punching trees.

Stone looked at the dot on the map. A single blinking point, wandering in circles, probably cold and hungry and lost in a world that was vast and dark and terrifying.

He remembered being that dot.

They all did.

"Let's go," Stone said.

They found the new player on the riverbank, trying to build a dirt hut on the wrong side of the water. It was almost painful to watch—the blocks placed in a crooked square, no door, a single torch on the outside where it did no good, a crafting table on the ground getting rained on.

The player saw them approach and froze. Five figures in enchanted netherite, glowing with beacon effects, weapons gleaming. The new player's character model stepped back slowly, wooden sword raised.

Stone stopped at the river's edge. The water flowed between them, clear and shallow.

"Easy," he said, his voice calm. "We're not going to hurt you."

The new player didn't move.

Red stepped forward, then stopped herself. She looked at Stone. Then at Brick, who was already pulling extra food from his inventory. At Pick, who had a bundle of spare tools. At Gear, who

had a written book in hand—the first book, the guide to starting out.

For a long moment, nobody spoke.

Then Red did something she rarely did. She sheathed her sword. Completely. It disappeared from her hand, and suddenly she was just a person standing on a riverbank, holding nothing but goodwill.

She walked across the river, water splashing around her boots, and stopped a few blocks from the new player.

"You look like you could use a hand," she said.

The new player lowered their wooden sword.

They brought the new player back to the base. Brick handed over a stack of cooked steak. Pick gave them iron tools—a full set, with extras. Gear explained the bed system, the respawn anchor setup, the safe zone.

Red walked them through the base, showing them the farms, the storage hall, the beacon tower. The new player's character kept stopping to look up at the builds, jaw visibly dropping in the game's limited way of showing awe.

Stone watched from the entrance, arms crossed, a small smile on his face.

Red caught his eye and nodded. One of those nods that said: *This is good. This is right.*

That evening, the five of them gathered on the obsidian platform again. The new player was asleep in one of the spare rooms, full of steak and iron and the first real safety they'd felt in this world.

The stars came out. The beacon beams reached for them.

"You know what I realized?" Stone said.

"What?" Red asked.

"We spent all this time trying to beat the game. The dragon, the Wither, the monuments, the challenges. We thought victory meant conquering everything."

"And now?"

Stone gestured at the base below them. At the village lights flickering in the distance. At the new player, tucked safely inside the walls. At Gear's lights blinking in a steady rhythm, at Brick's fountain still running, at Pick's library full of knowledge waiting to be shared.

"Now I realize there's nothing to beat. The game doesn't end. The credits roll and then the sun comes up again. And every day you get to decide what comes next."

Brick nodded slowly. "The building never stops."

"The learning never stops," Pick added.

"The automation never stops," Gear said, deadpan.

Red laughed—a real laugh, the kind she didn't let out often. "And the planning never stops. Guess I'm stuck with you idiots forever."

"Stuck," Stone repeated, and the word tasted like home.

The new player woke up the next morning to a chest at the foot of their bed. Inside: a full set of iron armor, a diamond pickaxe, a stack of torches, and a book.

The book was titled: *So You Just Spawned: A Beginner's Guide to Survival* by Pick. On the inside cover, someone had written in flowing script: *Welcome to the world. It's big and it's scary and it's beautiful. Build something. Help someone. Make it yours.*

And at the bottom, in Red's messy handwriting:

P.S. When you're ready, there's a village to the east that could use a builder. Tell them Red sent you.

The new player stood in the doorway of the base, looking out at the rising sun, at the beacon towers, at the fields and farms and the sprawling monument to everything five people had built together.

They put on the iron armor. They took a step forward.

And somewhere behind them, in the glow of a thousand torches, a crew of five misfits who had beaten every monster and mined every mountain watched them go, one last time, before turning back to their own unwinnable, unending, beautiful game.

Minecraft Successful

The game isn't about beating it.

It's about the crew you build along the way.

Thank you for reading!

*"Minecraft isn't about beating the game.
It's about the crew you build along the way."*